CHAPTER 03

The Middle English Period

Part A · English Literature · c. 1066 – 1500

3.1 The Middle English Period at a Glance

The **Middle English Period** is the stretch of English history and literature that lies between the **Old English (Anglo-Saxon) Period** and the **Renaissance**. It begins with the **Norman Conquest of 1066** and ends at about **1485–1500**, when the Tudor kings came to the throne, the printing press had arrived in England, and the new learning of the Renaissance was beginning to reach the country. It is called "Middle" because both the English *language* and English *literature* of these four centuries sit in the middle: they are no longer the Old English of *Beowulf*, but not yet the Modern English of Shakespeare.

Different textbooks give slightly different dates. The most common ones are **1066–1500**, **1066–1485** and **1100–1500**. In examinations, **1066–1500** is the safest answer, and **1066** (the Norman Conquest) is always the starting point.

For easy study, the period is divided into three smaller ages:

Sub-period	Years	Also called	Leading figures
The Anglo-Norman Period	1066 – 1340 (some books: 1066 – 1350)	The Age of French influence	Geoffrey of Monmouth, Layamon, Orm, the poet of *The Owl and the Nightingale*
The Age of Chaucer	1340 – 1400	The Golden Age of Middle English	Chaucer, Langland, Gower, Wycliffe, the Pearl Poet, Mandeville
The Fifteenth Century	1400 – 1485/1500	The Age of Transition; the Barren or Dark Age; the Age of Chaucer's Imitators	Lydgate, Hoccleve, the Scottish Chaucerians, Malory, Caxton

> **Remember:** The Middle English Period is named after the *language* (Middle English). The middle sub-period is named after its greatest *writer* (the Age of Chaucer). The year **1340** is used because Chaucer was born around then, and **1400** because he died in that year.

3.1.1 The Norman Conquest (1066)

In January 1066 the English king **Edward the Confessor** died without a son. The English nobles crowned **Harold Godwinson** as **King Harold II**. But **William, Duke of Normandy** (a region of northern France), said that Edward had promised the throne to him. In September 1066 Harold defeated a Norwegian invader, **Harald Hardrada**, at the **Battle of Stamford Bridge** in the north. Only a few days later William landed in the south. Harold rushed back, and on **14 October 1066** the two armies met at the **Battle of Hastings**. Harold was killed (according to tradition, by an arrow in the eye) and the English army was defeated. William was crowned king in Westminster Abbey on **Christmas Day 1066** and became known as **William the Conqueror**.

The **Normans** were originally *Norsemen* (Vikings) who had settled in northern France about 150 years earlier. By 1066 they had given up their own language and spoke a dialect of French. So the conquest of England by the Normans brought French language and French culture to the country. William replaced almost all the English (Saxon) nobles, bishops and abbots with Normans. Two famous records of this time are the **Bayeux Tapestry**, a long embroidered cloth showing the story of the Conquest, and the **Domesday Book** (1086), a great survey of the land and property of England ordered by William.

3.1.2 England with Three Languages

After the Conquest, England became a country of three languages, each with its own job:

- **Latin** — the language of the Church, of learning, of scholarship and of most official records.
- **French** (the Anglo-Norman dialect) — the language of the king, the court, the nobility, the law courts and polite society. Most literature written for the upper class was in French.
- **English** — the language of the ordinary people: peasants, labourers, servants and small traders. It was spoken everywhere, but for about 150 years very little serious literature was written in it.

Because English was "pushed down" to the common people, it was free to change quickly, without the control of scholars. This is why Middle English is so different from Old English.

3.1.3 How the English Language Changed

1. A flood of French words. Thousands of French words entered English during this period — perhaps about 10,000, of which roughly three-quarters are still in use. They came especially in the areas the Normans controlled:

- *Government:* government, parliament, crown, state, sovereign, minister, royal, empire.
- *Law:* justice, judge, jury, court, crime, prison, verdict, accuse, plaintiff.
- *Religion:* religion, prayer, sermon, saint, mercy, faith, chapel.
- *War:* army, navy, battle, soldier, enemy, captain, siege.
- *Fashion and fine living:* fashion, dress, robe, jewel, dinner, supper, feast, sauce, roast.

A famous example is the pairs of words for animals and their meat. The **live animal** usually keeps its old English name, because English-speaking peasants looked after it; the **meat** has a French name, because it was served at the tables of the French-speaking lords:

Live animal (English)	Meat (from French)
ox, cow	beef (*boeuf*)
swine, pig	pork (*porc*)
sheep	mutton (*mouton*)

Live animal (English)	Meat (from French)
calf	veal (*veau*)
deer	venison (*venaison*)

Sir Walter Scott later made this point in the first chapter of his novel ***Ivanhoe*** (1819), in a conversation between the jester Wamba and the swineherd Gurth.

2. Simpler grammar. Old English had many word-endings (inflections) to show case, number and gender, as modern German still does. In Middle English most of these endings were lost. Grammatical gender disappeared, the plural ending *-s* spread to most nouns, and word order (Subject – Verb – Object) became fixed and important.

3. New spellings. French-trained scribes changed English spelling. Old English *cw* became *qu* (*cwen → queen*), *sc* became *sh* (*scip → ship*), *c* became *ch* (*cild → child*), and *u* became *ou* (*hus → house*). The old letters **þ** (thorn) and **ð** (eth) were slowly replaced by *th*.

4. Dialects. Middle English had five main dialects: **Northern, East Midland, West Midland, Southern** and **Kentish**. Writers wrote in their own local dialect; for example, *Sir Gawain and the Green Knight* is in a North-West Midland dialect, while Chaucer wrote in the London dialect. The **East Midland dialect**, the speech of **London**, slowly became the basis of **Standard English**. The reasons were: London was the capital and the centre of trade; the universities of Oxford and Cambridge were in that region; it was the most populous area; Chaucer wrote in it; and later **Caxton** printed his books in it.

3.1.4 The Revival of English: Important Dates

Slowly, English won back its place as the language of the whole nation. The main steps were these:

- **1204** — **King John** lost Normandy to the French king. The Norman nobles now had to choose between England and France; those who stayed began to think of themselves as English.
- **1215** — **King John** sealed the **Magna Carta** (the "Great Charter", written in Latin) at **Runnymede**. It limited the power of the king.
- **1258** — The **Provisions of Oxford**: King Henry III issued a proclamation in **English** (as well as French and Latin) — the first official government document in English since the Conquest.
- **1337–1453** — The **Hundred Years' War** with France. French became the language of the enemy, and patriotic feeling favoured English.
- **1348–1350** — The **Black Death** (bubonic plague) killed perhaps a third of the population. Workers became scarce and valuable, so the English-speaking labouring class grew in importance.
- **1362** — The **Statute of Pleading** made English the language of the law courts, and Parliament was opened with a speech in English for the first time.
- **1381** — The **Peasants' Revolt**, led by **Wat Tyler** and the priest **John Ball**, whose famous rhyme asked: *"When Adam delved and Eve span, / Who was then the gentleman?"* (When Adam dug the earth and Eve spun thread, who was the nobleman then?)
- **1385** — **John of Trevisa** recorded that English had replaced French as the language of teaching in the grammar schools.
- **1399** — **Henry IV** became king; he was the first king since the Conquest whose mother tongue was English, and he claimed the throne in an English speech.
- **1476** — **William Caxton** set up the first printing press in England at **Westminster**.
- **1485** — The **Battle of Bosworth** ended the **Wars of the Roses**; **Henry VII** began the **Tudor** dynasty. In the same year Caxton printed Malory's ***Le Morte d'Arthur***. Many historians take 1485 as the end of the Middle Ages in England.

3.2 General Features of Middle English Literature

1. **Religious and moral purpose.** The Church controlled learning, so a great deal of the literature is religious: sermons, saints' lives, prayers, Bible stories and moral guides. Even entertaining works usually end with a moral.
2. **Three languages.** Works were written in Latin, French and English. A single poet, **John Gower**, wrote long poems in all three.
3. **The romance.** The most popular kind of story was the **romance**: a tale of knights, chivalry, love and adventure, often with magic and marvels. (See 3.3.3.)
4. **Courtly love.** Many poems describe a knight's devoted, suffering and respectful love for a noble lady. (See 3.3.4.)
5. **Allegory and the dream vision.** Poets often presented ideas as persons (Truth, Reason, Death, Good Deeds) and set their poems inside a dream. Chaucer's early poems and Langland's *Piers Plowman* are dream visions.
6. **Two kinds of verse.** French-style **rhymed, syllabic verse** (used by Chaucer) existed side by side with the old English **alliterative verse** (used by Langland and the Gawain Poet).
7. **Anonymity.** Many works — romances, lyrics, ballads, plays — have no known author.
8. **Growth of realism and humour.** By the time of Chaucer, literature had begun to show real men and women of all classes, with humour and satire.
9. **Drama out of the Church.** Religious plays grew from church services into the great **mystery** and **morality** plays performed in the streets (see 3.12).
10. **Prose develops slowly.** Poetry was the main form, but prose grew steadily, through Wycliffe's Bible, the mystics, Mandeville, and finally Malory.

3.3 Literature of the Anglo-Norman Period (1066–1340)

For about a century after the Conquest, very little was written in English. The educated wrote in Latin or French. When English writing returned in about 1200, it was mostly religious. The important works and writers are given below.

3.3.1 Chronicles and the Birth of the Arthurian Legend

The Peterborough Chronicle. The *Anglo-Saxon Chronicle* (a year-by-year history begun in King Alfred's time) was continued at Peterborough Abbey until **1154**. Its last entries show Old English changing into Middle English, and it describes the sufferings of the people during the civil war of King Stephen's reign.

Geoffrey of Monmouth — *Historia Regum Britanniae* (c. 1136). *The History of the Kings of Britain*, written in **Latin**, is a mostly legendary history of Britain from its supposed founder **Brutus** (a great-grandson of the Trojan hero Aeneas) down to the 7th century. It gave the first full story of **King Arthur**, **Merlin** and Arthur's wife **Guinevere**. It is also the source of the stories of **King Lear** (Leir) and **Cymbeline** later used by **Shakespeare**. Geoffrey also wrote the *Vita Merlini* (Life of Merlin).

Wace — *Roman de Brut* (1155). A Norman poet from Jersey, Wace turned Geoffrey's history into French verse and dedicated it to **Queen Eleanor of Aquitaine**. He was the **first writer to mention the Round Table**.

Layamon — *Brut* (c. 1190–1215). Layamon (also written **Laȝamon**), a priest of Areley Kings in Worcestershire, translated and expanded Wace's poem into **English alliterative verse** of about 16,000 lines. It is the **first poem in English to tell the story of King Arthur**, and it is the most important English poem of the early Middle English Period.

3.3.2 Religious and Moral Works

- ***The Ormulum*** (c. 1200) by **Orm** (Ormin), an Augustinian canon. It is a long series of verse paraphrases of the Gospels with sermons explaining them. It is famous for Orm's peculiar spelling system: he doubled consonants after short vowels, which tells us how English was pronounced in his time.
- ***The Owl and the Nightingale*** (c. 1200). A lively poem of about 1,800 lines in octosyllabic (eight-syllable) rhyming couplets. It is a **debate** between a grave, serious **Owl**, who stands for wisdom, religion and sober poetry, and a cheerful **Nightingale**, who stands for love, joy and song. They agree to let **Master Nicholas of Guildford** judge the argument, and the poem ends before a verdict is given. Nicholas may have been the author. It is the **earliest debate poem in English** and shows real humour and liveliness.
- ***Ancrene Riwle*** or ***Ancrene Wisse*** (*The Rule* or *Guide for Anchoresses*, early 13th century). A book of advice in **prose** written for three sisters who lived as religious recluses (anchoresses). It is gentle, practical and full of homely examples, and is one of the finest pieces of early Middle English prose.
- ***Cursor Mundi*** (*The Runner of the World*, c. 1300). A huge religious poem of about 30,000 lines telling the history of the world from the Creation to Doomsday.
- **Robert Mannyng of Brunne — *Handlyng Synne*** (1303). A collection of stories illustrating the various sins, translated from a French work. Its lively tales give a picture of everyday life.

3.3.3 The Romance

The **romance** (from *romanz*, the old word for the French language) was a long story, in verse and later in prose, about knights, their adventures, their battles, their love for noble ladies, and the marvels they met. The French poet **Jean Bodel** (12th century) divided the romances into three great "Matters" (subjects), and English critics later added a fourth:

The "Matter"	Subject	Examples
Matter of Britain	King Arthur and his knights	Layamon's *Brut*, *Sir Gawain and the Green Knight*, Malory's *Le Morte d'Arthur*
Matter of France	Charlemagne and his warriors (the Paladins)	*The Song of Roland* (*Chanson de Roland*)
Matter of Rome	Stories from ancient Greece and Rome: Troy, Thebes, Alexander	Chaucer's *Troilus and Criseyde*, Lydgate's *Troy Book*
Matter of England	English heroes	*King Horn*, *Havelok the Dane*, *Guy of Warwick*, *Bevis of Hampton*

- ***King Horn*** (c. 1225) — the **earliest surviving romance in English**. Prince Horn is cast out to sea by invaders, wins the love of the princess Rymenhild, and returns to win back his kingdom.
- ***Havelok the Dane*** (c. 1280–1300) — Havelok, the rightful heir to the Danish throne, is brought up in poverty by a fisherman called Grim (the legendary founder of the town of Grimsby) and finally regains his kingdom.
- ***Sir Orfeo*** (c. 1300) — a **Breton lay** (a short romance in the style of Brittany) that retells the Greek myth of Orpheus and Eurydice, but with a happy ending: the king wins his wife back from the Fairy King.
- **Marie de France** (12th century), a French poet living in England, wrote the famous **Lais**, short verse romances of love and magic.

3.3.4 Courtly Love

Courtly love (in French *amour courtois*, a term made popular by the critic **Gaston Paris** in 1883) was an ideal of love found in the romances and lyrics. The lover is usually a knight; the lady is of high rank and often married to someone else. The knight treats her almost like a goddess, serves and obeys her, suffers sleeplessness and sickness for her sake, and tries to become a better man to deserve her. This ideal came from the troubadour poets of southern France and spread across Europe. It influenced Chaucer's *Troilus and Criseyde*, the love of **Lancelot and Guinevere** in Malory, and, much later, the sonnets of the Elizabethan poets.

3.3.5 The Early Lyric

The most famous early English lyric is the **"Cuckoo Song"** (c. 1260), a joyful song to be sung as a round:

> *"Sumer is icumen in, / Lhude sing cuccu!"*
> Summer has come in; loudly sing, cuckoo!
> — "Sumer is icumen in", c. 1260

It is the **oldest surviving English song** with words and music together. In the 20th century the poet **Ezra Pound** wrote a comic parody of it called "Ancient Music", which begins *"Winter is icumen in, / Lhude sing Goddamm."* Other early lyrics include "Alysoun" and "Lenten is come with love to toune", found in the Harley Lyrics manuscript (c. 1340).

3.4 The Age of Chaucer (1340–1400)

The second half of the 14th century was the **first great age of English literature**. In these sixty years English finally became the language of serious literature, and four great writers appeared at almost the same time:

- **Geoffrey Chaucer** — the court poet; realistic, humorous and full of sympathy for all kinds of people; influenced by French and Italian poetry; wrote in rhymed verse in the London dialect.
- **William Langland** — the poet of the poor; a serious moral and religious reformer; wrote in the old English alliterative metre.
- **John Gower** — a learned moral poet who wrote in English, French and Latin.
- **John Wycliffe** — a religious reformer, who led the first complete translation of the Bible into English and wrote vigorous English prose.

Alongside them worked the unknown **Pearl Poet** (author of *Sir Gawain and the Green Knight*), the writer known as **Sir John Mandeville**, the Scottish poet **John Barbour**, and the religious writers called the **mystics**. (Gower, the Pearl Poet and the others are described in 3.10.)

3.4.1 The Background of the Age

The literature of this age grew out of a troubled and changing society:

- **The Hundred Years' War** (1337–1453) brought glory at first (the victories of Crécy, 1346, and Poitiers, 1356) and then heavy taxes and defeat.
- **The Black Death** (1348–1350, with later outbreaks) killed huge numbers and shook people's faith and the old social order.
- **The Peasants' Revolt** (1381) showed the anger of the poor against taxes and the landowners.
- **Corruption in the Church.** Many monks, friars, pardoners and summoners were greedy and worldly. From **1378** the **Great Schism** gave Europe two rival Popes, one in Rome and one in Avignon. Chaucer, Langland and Wycliffe all attack these abuses.
- **The rise of the middle class.** Merchants, lawyers, doctors and craftsmen were growing rich and important in the towns. Chaucer's pilgrims include many of them.
- **Contact with Italy.** Chaucer travelled to Italy and read **Dante, Petrarch and Boccaccio**, bringing the early light of the Italian Renaissance into English poetry.

3.4.2 The Alliterative Revival

In the middle of the 14th century, especially in the **West and North-West Midlands**, poets returned to the old **alliterative verse** of Old English poetry. In this metre each long line is divided into two halves, and three or four of its stressed words begin with the same sound — for example, *"In a somer seson, whan softe was the sonne"*. This movement is called the **Alliterative Revival**. Its chief works are Langland's ***Piers Plowman***, ***Sir Gawain and the Green Knight***, ***Pearl***, the alliterative ***Morte Arthure*** and ***Wynnere and Wastoure***.

Chaucer, a Londoner, did not use this metre, and he gently mocks it through his Parson, who says:

> *"But trusteth wel, I am a Southren man; / I kan nat geeste 'rum, ram, ruf,' by lettre."*
> Believe me, I am a southern man; I cannot tell a story in "rum, ram, ruf" — that is, by alliteration.
> — Chaucer, *The Parson's Prologue*

3.5 Geoffrey Chaucer (c. 1343 – 1400)

Born: c. 1343 (some books say 1340), London
Died: 25 October 1400, London; buried in Westminster Abbey
Father: John Chaucer, a wealthy vintner (wine merchant)
Wife: Philippa (de) Roet, a lady-in-waiting to the Queen
Patron: John of Gaunt, Duke of Lancaster
Main titles: Father of English Poetry; Father of English Literature; the Morning Star of Song
Masterpiece: *The Canterbury Tales*
Verse forms he introduced: the heroic couplet and rhyme royal

Geoffrey Chaucer is the greatest English poet of the Middle Ages and one of the greatest poets in the whole of English literature. Before him, English poetry was mostly religious, anonymous or rough. Chaucer gave it grace, music, humour and, above all, **real human beings**. Because he was the first English poet of the first rank, and because almost all later English poetry learned from him, he is called **"the Father of English Poetry"**.

3.5.1 Life and Career

Chaucer was born in **London** around 1343, the son of **John Chaucer**, a prosperous wine merchant. As a boy he became a **page** in the household of **Elizabeth de Burgh, Countess of Ulster**, the wife of **Prince Lionel**, a son of King **Edward III**. This gave him an early education in court manners and French poetry.

In **1359–60** he fought in the Hundred Years' War in France, was **taken prisoner**, and was set free when a ransom was paid; King Edward III himself contributed £16. In about **1366** he married **Philippa Roet**. Philippa's sister **Katherine Swynford** later became the wife of the powerful **John of Gaunt, Duke of Lancaster**, Chaucer's chief patron. Through this connection Chaucer was linked to the royal family.

For the rest of his life Chaucer was a busy public servant, not a full-time poet. He served three kings — **Edward III, Richard II and Henry IV**. He travelled on diplomatic missions to **France, Flanders and Italy**. His journeys to **Italy in 1372–73** (Genoa and Florence) and **1378** (Milan) were especially important, because there he came to know the works of **Dante, Petrarch and Boccaccio**. From **1374 to 1386** he was **Controller of Customs** for wool, skins and hides in the **Port of London**, and

lived in a house over **Aldgate**, one of the gates of the city. He became a **Justice of the Peace** and a **Member of Parliament for Kent** (1386). From **1389 to 1391** he was **Clerk of the King's Works**, in charge of building and repairs at royal palaces, including the Tower of London and Westminster. In his last years he leased a house in the garden of **Westminster Abbey**.

Chaucer died on **25 October 1400** and was buried in Westminster Abbey. He was buried there because he lived within its grounds, not specially as a poet; but in **1556** a grander tomb was built for him, and later poets were buried near him. That part of the Abbey is now called **Poets' Corner**, and **Chaucer was the first poet buried there**.

His knowledge of so many kinds of work — the court, the army, trade, the law, the customs house, building, foreign travel — explains why he could describe people of every class with such truth.

3.5.2 Titles and Epithets

Title	Given by / Reason
Father of English Poetry	**John Dryden**, in the *Preface to Fables Ancient and Modern* (1700)
Father of English Literature	He was the first major writer in English whose works are still read with pleasure
Father of the English Language (in some books)	His London (East Midland) dialect became the basis of Standard English
The Morning Star of Song	**Lord Tennyson**, in "A Dream of Fair Women"
The well of English undefiled	**Edmund Spenser**, in *The Faerie Queene* (Book IV)
The Morning Star of the Renaissance (in some books)	He brought Italian Renaissance influence into English poetry
The first finder of our fair language	**Thomas Hoccleve**, his pupil and admirer

> **Do not confuse: Chaucer** is "the Morning Star of Song"; **John Wycliffe** is "the Morning Star of the Reformation". **Edmund Spenser** (not Chaucer) is "the Poet's Poet", a title given by Charles Lamb.

3.5.3 The Three Periods of Chaucer's Work

Scholars divide Chaucer's literary career into three periods, according to the main influence on his writing.

Period	Years (approx.)	Main influence	Chief works
1. French Period	up to 1372	French poets, especially the *Roman de la Rose*	*The Romaunt of the Rose* (translation), *The Book of the Duchess*, *An ABC*
2. Italian Period	1372 – 1386	Dante, Petrarch and Boccaccio	*The House of Fame*, *The Parliament of Fowls*, *Troilus and Criseyde*, *The Legend of Good Women*, *Boece*, *Anelida and Arcite*
3. English Period (Period of Maturity)	1386 – 1400	His own observation of English life	*The Canterbury Tales*, *A Treatise on the Astrolabe*, short poems

3.5.4 Works of the French Period

The Romaunt of the Rose

This is Chaucer's translation (only partly his) of the famous French allegorical poem ***Le Roman de la Rose***, begun by **Guillaume de Lorris** and completed by **Jean de Meun** in the 13th century. In it a young dreamer enters the Garden of Love and seeks to win a **Rose**, which stands for his beloved lady. Figures such as Fair Welcome, Danger, Shame and Reason help or block him. The poem taught Chaucer the dream-vision form and the language of courtly love. The English phrase **"castles in Spain"** (day-dreams) appears here for the first time in English: *"Thou shalt make castels thanne in Spayne."*

The Book of the Duchess (c. 1369–1370)

This is **Chaucer's first important original poem** and an **elegy** (a poem of mourning). It was written on the death of **Blanche, Duchess of Lancaster**, the first wife of John of Gaunt.

Summary: The poet cannot sleep. He reads the sad story of **Ceyx and Alcyone** from Ovid and falls asleep. In his dream he joins a hunt and meets a sorrowful **Knight in Black** sitting under a tree. With seeming innocence the dreamer asks why he grieves. The Knight describes his lost lady, **"good faire White"** (a pun on the name *Blanche*, which means "white" in French), her beauty, her goodness and their love. At last he says plainly: *"She ys ded!"* The dreamer replies, *"Is that youre los? Be God, hyt ys routhe!"* (Is that your loss? By God, it is a pity!) A bell strikes, and the poet wakes with the book still in his hand. The poem is written in **octosyllabic couplets** (lines of eight syllables rhyming in pairs).

An ABC

A prayer to the Virgin Mary, translated from French, in which each stanza begins with the next letter of the alphabet.

3.5.5 Works of the Italian Period

The House of Fame (c. 1379–1380)

A comic dream-vision in three books, written in octosyllabic couplets, and left **unfinished**. The dreamer, named **"Geffrey"**, first sees the story of Dido and Aeneas painted on the walls of the Temple of Venus. A talkative **golden eagle** then carries him up into the sky — lecturing him on science all the way — to the **House of Fame**, where the goddess Fame gives good or bad reputation to people quite at random. Next he visits the whirling **House of Rumour**, full of gossip and news. The poem stops just as "a man of gret auctorite" (a man of great authority) is about to speak. It shows the influence of Dante's *Divine Comedy* and is full of Chaucer's gentle self-mockery.

The Parliament of Fowls (c. 1380–1382)

Also called ***The Parlement of Foules*** (*foules* means "birds"). This poem of 699 lines is written in **rhyme royal**, and it is **the first poem in which Chaucer used the rhyme royal stanza**.

Summary: The poet reads Cicero's *Dream of Scipio* and dreams that he is led to a beautiful garden and the Temple of Venus. Then he sees the goddess **Nature** presiding over a great gathering ("parliament") of birds, who have come on **St Valentine's Day** to choose their mates. Three noble **tercel (male) eagles** all ask for the hand of a lovely **formel (female) eagle**. A long and funny debate follows among the lower birds — the goose, the duck, the cuckoo and the turtle-dove — each giving opinions according to

its class. Finally the formel eagle asks for **a year's delay** before choosing. The other birds pick their mates and fly off singing a **roundel** in praise of summer. The poem may celebrate the betrothal of **King Richard II** and **Anne of Bohemia**.

It is the **earliest known poem to connect St Valentine's Day with love**, so it is often linked with the origin of the Valentine's Day tradition.

IMPORTANT QUOTATIONS

"The lyf so short, the craft so long to lerne, / Th'assay so hard, so sharp the conquerynge."

Life is so short, and the art (of love) so long to learn; the attempt is so hard, the conquest so painful.

— opening lines (from Hippocrates' *Ars longa, vita brevis*)

"For this was on Seynt Valentynes day, / Whan every foul cometh there to chese his make."

For this was on St Valentine's Day, when every bird comes there to choose his mate.

— lines 309–310

"Now welcome, somer, with thy sonne softe, / That hast this wintres wedres overshake."

Welcome, summer, with your gentle sun, that has shaken off the storms of winter.

— the birds' roundel

Troilus and Criseyde (c. 1385)

This is **Chaucer's greatest complete poem**, a long narrative of more than 8,000 lines in **five books**, written in **rhyme royal**. Its source is ***Il Filostrato*** by the Italian poet **Giovanni Boccaccio**. Many critics call it **"the first psychological novel in verse"**, because it shows the inner thoughts and feelings of its characters so fully.

Summary: The story is set in **Troy** during the **Trojan War**. **Troilus**, a young prince and son of King **Priam**, laughs at lovers — until he sees the beautiful young widow **Criseyde** in a temple and falls deeply in love. Criseyde's father, the priest **Calchas**, has foreseen Troy's fall and gone over to the Greeks. Troilus's friend **Pandarus**, who is Criseyde's uncle, cleverly arranges meetings between the two; after much hesitation Criseyde returns Troilus's love, and they are happy together for a time. Then the Trojans agree to **exchange Criseyde** for the Trojan prisoner **Antenor**, and she must go to her father in the Greek camp. She promises faithfully to return within **ten days**. But in the Greek camp, lonely and afraid, she accepts the attention of the Greek warrior **Diomede** and gives him her heart. Troilus waits in vain, learns the truth when he finds his brooch on Diomede's captured cloak, and is finally **killed by Achilles** in battle. His soul rises to the eighth heavenly sphere, from where he looks down, laughs at the sorrow of those weeping for him, and understands how foolish it is to set our hearts on earthly love instead of on God.

Points to note:

- Chaucer calls it **"the double sorwe of Troilus"** — his sorrow first in winning love and then in losing it.
- **Pandarus** is a brilliant comic character; from his name comes the English word **"pander"**, meaning a go-between in love affairs.
- Chaucer treats Criseyde with great sympathy and does not simply condemn her.
- In Book I, Troilus's love song (**"Canticus Troili"**) is a translation of a sonnet by **Petrarch** — **the first translation of Petrarch into English**.
- At the end Chaucer dedicates the poem to **"moral Gower"** (the poet John Gower) and **"philosophical Strode"** (Ralph Strode, an Oxford scholar).
- The same story was told later by **Robert Henryson** in ***The Testament of Cresseid*** and by **Shakespeare** in ***Troilus and Cressida***.

IMPORTANT QUOTATIONS

"The double sorwe of Troilus to tellen, / That was the kyng Priamus sone of Troye."

To tell the double sorrow of Troilus, who was the son of King Priam of Troy.

— Book I, opening lines

"If no love is, O God, what fele I so?"

If there is no such thing as love, O God, what is it that I feel?

— Book I, the "Canticus Troili" (from Petrarch)

"For of fortunes sharp adversitee / The worste kynde of infortune is this, / A man to han ben in prosperitee, / And it remembren whan it passed is."

Of all the sharp blows of Fortune, the worst kind of misfortune is to have been happy once, and to remember it when it is gone.

— Book III

"Go, litel bok, go, litel myn tragedye."

Go, little book, go, my little tragedy.

— Book V

"O moral Gower, this book I directe / To the."

O moral Gower, I dedicate this book to you.

— Book V

The Legend of Good Women (c. 1386)

Summary: In the **Prologue**, the poet, who loves the **daisy** above all flowers, falls asleep and dreams that the **God of Love** angrily accuses him of insulting women and love by translating *The Romance of the Rose* and by writing about the unfaithful Criseyde. The God's queen, **Alceste** (who in Greek legend gave her life for her husband), defends the poet and orders a penance: he must write the "legends" (lives) of women who were **faithful in love** and suffered for it, as the saints suffered for their faith. Nine legends follow, about ten women: **Cleopatra, Thisbe, Dido, Hypsipyle and Medea, Lucrece, Ariadne, Philomela, Phyllis** and **Hypermnestra**. The work is **unfinished**.

It is important in the history of English verse because it is **the first poem in English written in the heroic couplet** (pairs of rhyming lines in iambic pentameter) — the metre Chaucer then used for most of *The Canterbury Tales*.

"And as for me, though that I konne but lyte, / On bokes for to rede I me delyte."

As for me, though I know but little, I delight in reading books.

— Prologue

Other Works of this Period

- ***Boece*** — a **prose translation** of the Latin ***Consolation of Philosophy*** by the Roman philosopher **Boethius**, which teaches that true happiness cannot depend on Fortune. Its ideas run through *Troilus* and *The Knight's Tale*.
- ***Anelida and Arcite*** — an unfinished poem of a faithful queen deserted by a false lover.

3.5.6 *The Canterbury Tales* (c. 1387 – 1400)

The Canterbury Tales is Chaucer's masterpiece and the most famous work of Middle English literature. It is a **collection of stories** told by a group of pilgrims, held together by a **frame story** (a story that contains the other stories). Chaucer worked on it during the last thirteen years of his life and **left it unfinished**. It contains about **17,000 lines**, mostly in **heroic couplets**; two tales are in **prose**, and some are in **rhyme royal**.

The Frame Story

The poem opens in **April**. The narrator — Chaucer himself, as a simple pilgrim — is staying at the **Tabard Inn** in **Southwark**, just south of London, ready to go on a pilgrimage to the shrine of **St Thomas Becket** at **Canterbury Cathedral**. (Thomas Becket, Archbishop of Canterbury, was murdered in his cathedral in **1170** and was soon made a saint; his shrine was the most popular place of pilgrimage in England.) That evening a company of **"nyne and twenty"** (twenty-nine) pilgrims arrives, and Chaucer joins them.

The cheerful innkeeper, **Harry Bailly**, called **the Host**, proposes a game. Each pilgrim will tell **two tales on the way** to Canterbury and **two on the way back**. The pilgrim who tells the tale *"of best sentence and moost solaas"* (with the best moral meaning and the most enjoyment) will win **a free supper** at the Tabard, paid for by all the others. The Host himself will ride with them as guide and judge. Everyone agrees. Lots are drawn, and the **Knight** tells the first tale.

According to this plan there should have been about **120 tales**. Chaucer completed only **24** (some of them unfinished), and the pilgrims never reach Canterbury in the poem, nor return.

> **Exam point:** The General Prologue says the company was **29 pilgrims**. With **Chaucer** they make **30**, and with the **Host 31**. (If the "preestes thre" — three priests — are counted, the list in the Prologue actually gives a slightly larger number; this is a well-known puzzle. For exams, say **29 pilgrims**.) On the way, a **Canon** and his **Yeoman** join the group; the Canon soon rides away, and the Yeoman tells a tale.

The book is compared with ***The Decameron*** of **Boccaccio**, an Italian collection of 100 tales told by ten young people who have fled from the plague in Florence. But Chaucer's frame is far more lively: his storytellers come from **every class of society**, they argue and interrupt one another, and each tale suits the character of its teller.

The General Prologue

The **General Prologue** (858 lines) is the most famous part of the work. After the beautiful spring opening, Chaucer describes the pilgrims one by one — their clothes, faces, horses, habits and morals. Together they form **a picture gallery of 14th-century English society**: the **nobility** (Knight, Squire), the **Church** (Prioress, Monk, Friar, Parson, Summoner, Pardoner) and the **middle and working classes** (Merchant, Lawyer, Doctor, Franklin, Wife of Bath, Miller, Cook, Plowman and others). Each pilgrim is both a real individual and a **type** of a whole class. Chaucer's method is gentle **irony**: the narrator praises everyone, but the details he reports show us their faults.

THE OPENING OF THE GENERAL PROLOGUE

"Whan that Aprill with his shoures soote / The droghte of March hath perced to the roote, / And bathed every veyne in swich licour / Of which vertu engendred is the flour; / Whan Zephirus eek with his sweete breeth / Inspired hath in every holt and heeth / The tendre croppes, and the yonge sonne / Hath in the Ram his half cours yronne, / And smale foweles maken melodye, / That slepen al the nyght with open ye / (So priketh hem Nature in hir corages), / Thanne longen folk to goon on pilgrimages … / And specially from every shires ende / Of Engelond to Caunterbury they wende, / The hooly blisful martir for to seke, / That hem hath holpen whan that they were seeke."

When April with its sweet showers has pierced the drought of March to the root, and bathed every vein (of plants) in the moisture by whose power the flower is born; when the west wind (Zephyrus) with its sweet breath has breathed life into the tender shoots in every wood and field, and the young sun has run half its course in the sign of the Ram, and little birds make melody and sleep all night with open eyes (so Nature stirs their hearts) — then people long to go on pilgrimages … and especially, from every county's end of England, they go to Canterbury to seek the holy, blessed martyr (St Thomas Becket) who helped them when they were sick.

— *General Prologue*, lines 1–18

The Pilgrims and their Tales

Pilgrim	Chaucer's portrait in brief	Tale told
The Knight	A brave, noble and humble crusader; "a verray, parfit gentil knyght"	The Knight's Tale
The Squire	The Knight's son, 20 years old; a gay young lover who sings and plays the flute all day	The Squire's Tale (unfinished)
The Yeoman	The Knight's servant, a forester dressed in green	—
The Prioress (Madame Eglentyne)	Head of a nunnery; dainty and sentimental; weeps over a mouse in a trap; brooch reads *Amor vincit omnia*	The Prioress's Tale
The Second Nun	The Prioress's companion	The Second Nun's Tale
The Nun's Priest	One of the Prioress's priests	The Nun's Priest's Tale
The Monk	Fat, rich and worldly; loves hunting and fine horses more than prayer	The Monk's Tale
The Friar (Hubert)	A merry beggar-friar who sells easy forgiveness and knows every innkeeper	The Friar's Tale
The Merchant	Talks always of his profits; secretly in debt	The Merchant's Tale

Pilgrim	Chaucer's portrait in brief	Tale told
The Clerk of Oxford	A thin, poor, devoted student who loves books more than riches	The Clerk's Tale
The Sergeant of the Law (Man of Law)	A clever lawyer who "seemed busier than he was"	The Man of Law's Tale
The Franklin	A rich landowner who loves good food: "It snewed in his hous of mete and drynke"	The Franklin's Tale
The five Guilds-men	A Haberdasher, Carpenter, Weaver, Dyer and Tapestry-maker, proud of their guild	—
The Cook (Roger)	Their cook, skilled but with a sore on his shin	The Cook's Tale (unfinished)
The Shipman	A sea-captain, part sailor, part pirate	The Shipman's Tale
The Doctor of Physic	Learned in astrology; loves gold; "his studie was but litel on the Bible"	The Physician's Tale
The Wife of Bath (Alisoun)	A bold, gap-toothed, somewhat deaf cloth-maker who has had five husbands	The Wife of Bath's Tale
The Parson	A poor, holy and hard-working village priest — the ideal church-man	The Parson's Tale (prose)
The Plowman	The Parson's brother; an honest, hard-working peasant	—
The Miller (Robin)	A big, strong, coarse man who plays the bagpipes and steals corn	The Miller's Tale
The Manciple	Buyer of food for a lawyers' college; cleverer than his learned masters	The Manciple's Tale
The Reeve (Oswald)	A thin, bad-tempered estate manager who cheats his lord	The Reeve's Tale
The Summoner	Calls sinners to Church courts; has a pimpled, fiery-red face; takes bribes	The Summoner's Tale
The Pardoner	Sells pardons and false relics ("pigges bones") from Rome; a brilliant preacher against greed — and greedy himself	The Pardoner's Tale
The Host (Harry Bailly)	Innkeeper of the Tabard; guide and judge of the game	—
Chaucer (the narrator)	Shy, plump and quiet; called "elvyssh" (absent-minded) by the Host	Sir Thopas; The Tale of Melibee (prose)
The Canon's Yeoman	Joins on the road; servant of an alchemist	The Canon's Yeoman's Tale

Summaries of the Principal Tales

The Knight's Tale. The first tale, a noble **romance** based on Boccaccio's ***Teseida***. **Theseus, Duke of Athens**, captures two young Theban cousins, **Palamon** and **Arcite**, and keeps them in a tower. From their window both see and fall in love with **Emelye**, the sister of Theseus's wife, and their friendship turns into bitter rivalry. Arcite is released but returns in disguise to serve in Emelye's household; Palamon escapes; the two meet and fight in a wood. Theseus arranges a great **tournament** a year later to decide who will marry Emelye. Before the battle Arcite prays to **Mars** for victory, Palamon prays to **Venus** for Emelye, and Emelye prays to **Diana** to stay unmarried. Arcite wins the tournament, but his horse is frightened by a fury sent from the god **Saturn**; he is thrown and fatally injured. Before dying he generously commends Palamon to Emelye, and after a period of mourning Palamon marries her. Thus both prayers come true. The tale shows the power of Fortune and the need to accept God's order patiently.

The Miller's Tale. A comic **fabliau** (a short, coarse, funny story of trickery, usually about ordinary townspeople). An old Oxford carpenter, **John**, has a young wife, **Alisoun**. Their lodger, a clever student called **Nicholas**, persuades John that a second **Noah's Flood** is coming, so John spends the night in a tub hung from the roof, while Nicholas courts Alisoun. A vain parish clerk, **Absolon**, also courts her and is tricked; he takes revenge with a red-hot plough-blade. Nicholas's cry of "Water!" makes John think the flood has come; he cuts the rope and crashes to the floor, and the neighbours laugh at him as a madman. The tale mocks the Knight's Tale: here too two young men compete for one woman, but in a low, comic setting.

The Reeve's Tale. The Reeve, a carpenter himself, answers the Miller with another fabliau, in which a dishonest miller, **Symkyn of Trumpington**, cheats two Cambridge students, **John and Aleyn**, and is paid back by them. The two students speak a **Northern dialect** — one of the earliest uses of regional dialect for comic effect in English literature.

The Wife of Bath's Prologue and Tale. In her long **Prologue**, the **Wife of Bath** tells the story of her life and her five marriages, and argues boldly — against the Church writers of her time — that experience is a better guide than authority, and that wives should rule their husbands. Her **Tale** is an Arthurian story. A knight of King Arthur's court commits a crime against a maiden and is condemned to death, but **Queen Guinevere** gives him **a year and a day** to find out **"what thyng is it that wommen moost desiren"**. He cannot find the answer, until an ugly **old woman** (the "**loathly lady**") gives it to him on condition that he grant her next request. The answer — that women most desire **sovereignty** (mastery) over their husbands — saves his life, and the old woman then demands that he marry her. On their wedding night she lectures him on **"gentilesse"** — true nobility comes from good deeds, not from birth or wealth — and offers him a choice: to have her **ugly but faithful**, or **young and beautiful** but perhaps unfaithful. The knight leaves the choice to her. Having been given the mastery, she becomes **both beautiful and faithful**, and they live happily. The Wife of Bath is one of Chaucer's greatest comic characters and is often discussed as an early voice of women's independence.

The Clerk's Tale. A tale of **patience**, taken from **Petrarch's** Latin version of the last story in Boccaccio's *Decameron*. **Walter**, Marquis of Saluzzo, marries **Griselda**, a poor peasant girl, who promises to obey him in everything. To test her, he takes away her baby daughter and later her son, pretending to have them killed; then he pretends to divorce her and sends her home in her simple shift; finally he orders her to prepare the palace for his new young bride. Griselda bears everything without complaint. At last Walter reveals that the "bride" is their own daughter and that both children are alive, and husband and wife are reunited. The Clerk says he learned the story at Padua from **"Fraunceys Petrak, the lauriat poete"** (Francis Petrarch,

the poet laureate). **“Patient Griselda”** has become a byword for endless, uncomplaining patience.

The Merchant’s Tale. An old knight named **January** marries a young wife called **May**, who deceives him with his squire Damyan in a garden; the gods **Pluto and Proserpina** take opposite sides. The tale is a bitter satire on marriage between old and young.

The Squire’s Tale. An unfinished romance of the East about **Cambyuskan**, King of Tartary, who receives magic gifts: a flying horse of brass, a mirror that shows the future, a ring that lets its wearer understand the language of birds, and a sword that wounds and heals. **John Milton** refers to this unfinished tale in “Il Penseroso”: *“Or call up him that left half told / The story of Cambuscan bold.”*

The Franklin’s Tale. A **Breton lay** about **truth to one’s word** and **generosity**. **Dorigen**, the loving wife of the knight **Arveragus**, is courted by a young squire, **Aurelius**, while her husband is away. To get rid of him, she jokingly promises to love him if he removes all the black rocks from the coast of Brittany — rocks she fears will wreck her husband’s ship. Aurelius pays a magician-scholar of **Orléans** a thousand pounds to make the rocks seem to disappear. Dorigen is in despair, but Arveragus says that she must keep her promise, because *“Trouthe is the hyeste thyng that man may kepe”*. Aurelius, moved by this nobility, releases her from her promise; and the magician, moved in turn, cancels Aurelius’s debt. The Franklin ends by asking: **“Which was the mooste fre?”** — which of them was the most generous? The tale also contains Chaucer’s famous lines on love and freedom in marriage.

The Physician’s Tale. A Roman story from Livy: to save his daughter **Virginia** from the lust of a corrupt judge, **Appius**, her father **Virginius** kills her himself.

The Pardoner’s Tale. One of the most powerful stories in the book. In his **Prologue**, the Pardoner shamelessly admits that he cheats simple people with false relics, and that his sermon always has the same text: ***“Radix malorum est Cupiditas”*** — **“Greed (the love of money) is the root of all evil.”** He preaches against the very sin he practises. His **Tale** is an *exemplum* (a moral story used in a sermon). Three young **rioters** (drunkards and gamblers) are drinking in a tavern in Flanders when they hear that one of their friends has been killed by a secret thief called **Death**, who has killed thousands during the plague. Drunk and angry, they swear to find and kill Death. A mysterious, sorrowful **Old Man**, who longs to die but cannot, tells them they will find Death under a certain **oak tree**. There they find a heap of **gold florins** instead, and forget their oath. They draw lots, and the **youngest** goes to town to fetch bread and wine while the other two guard the gold. The two **plot to kill him** when he returns, so as to share the gold between them; meanwhile the youngest **poisons the wine** so as to keep all the gold himself. When he returns, the two stab him, then sit down to drink the poisoned wine — and **all three die**. They “found Death” after all. The tale is a perfect illustration of its moral and is famous for its tight construction and dramatic irony. At the end the Pardoner tries to sell his relics to the pilgrims, and quarrels with the Host.

The Prioress’s Tale. A **miracle of the Virgin Mary**, written in rhyme royal. A little Christian schoolboy in a city in Asia sings the hymn *“Alma redemptoris mater”* as he walks through the Jewish quarter; he is murdered and his body thrown into a pit, but by a miracle he continues to sing, and the body is found. The tale reflects the religious hostility to Jews common in medieval Europe, and modern readers find it disturbing.

Sir Thopas and Melibee (Chaucer’s own tales). When the Host asks Chaucer for a tale, Chaucer begins ***Sir Thopas***, a deliberately silly parody of the popular tail-rhyme romances of his day, with a ridiculous hero. The Host stops him rudely, calling it worthless “drasty rymyng”. Chaucer then tells the long, serious ***Tale of Melibee*** in **prose**, a moral allegory in which **Prudence** persuades her husband **Melibeus** to forgive his enemies instead of taking revenge. The joke is that the poet gives himself the worst tale in the book.

The Monk’s Tale. A series of short **“tragedies”** describing the falls of great people — Lucifer, Adam, Samson, Hercules, Nebuchadnezzar, Zenobia, Nero, Alexander, Julius Caesar, Croesus, Count Ugolino of Pisa (taken from Dante) and others. It gives the **medieval definition of tragedy**: the story of someone who falls from great prosperity into misery and ends wretchedly. The Knight finally stops the Monk because the tales are too depressing.

The Nun’s Priest’s Tale. A delightful **beast fable** and **mock-heroic** poem. In the yard of a poor widow lives a splendid rooster, **Chauntecleer**, the best crower in the land, with his favourite hen, **Pertelote**. Chauntecleer dreams that a beast like a dog is about to seize him. Pertelote laughs at his fear, says dreams mean nothing, and prescribes a laxative. Chauntecleer replies with a learned speech full of examples proving that dreams can come true — and then forgets his own warning. A sly fox, **Russell** (Daun Russell), **flatters** him by praising his father’s singing, and when Chauntecleer stretches his neck, closes his eyes and crows, the fox seizes him and runs off. The widow, her daughters, the dogs and all the farm animals give chase in a wild uproar. Chauntecleer, though in the fox’s mouth, cleverly suggests that the fox turn and shout insults at the pursuers; when the fox opens his mouth to speak, Chauntecleer escapes into a tree. The **moral**: beware of flattery, and do not speak when you should keep silent. The tale mocks learned argument and grand epic style by applying them to farmyard birds.

The Second Nun’s Tale. The life of **St Cecilia**, a Roman martyr, in rhyme royal.

The Canon’s Yeoman’s Tale. The Yeoman exposes the frauds of **alchemists**, who pretend they can turn base metals into gold.

The Manciple’s Tale. The god **Phoebus** has a white **crow** that can speak. The crow tells him that his wife is unfaithful; Phoebus kills her in anger, then regrets it, and punishes the crow by turning it **black** and taking away its voice. The moral is to guard one’s tongue.

The Parson’s Tale. The **last tale**, in **prose**: a long sermon on **penitence** and the **Seven Deadly Sins** (Pride, Envy, Wrath, Sloth, Avarice, Gluttony, Lust) and their remedies. It turns the pilgrimage to Canterbury into a symbol of the soul’s journey to the “Jerusalem celestial” (heavenly Jerusalem).

Chaucer’s Retraction. At the very end, Chaucer asks his readers to pray for him, and **“revokes”** (withdraws) those of his works

that are worldly or sinful, including "the tales of Caunterbury, thilke that sownen into synne" (those that tend towards sin).

Other Tales in Brief

- **The Cook's Tale** — the story of an idle London apprentice, **Perkyn Revelour**; it breaks off after about 58 lines.
- **The Man of Law's Tale** — **Constance**, a Roman emperor's daughter, is twice set adrift at sea and suffers many trials, reaching Northumbria, but her faith and patience bring her through.
- **The Friar's Tale** — a greedy summoner meets a devil disguised as a yeoman and is carried off to hell.
- **The Summoner's Tale** — the Summoner's angry reply, mocking a greedy friar who is tricked by a sick man.
- **The Shipman's Tale** — a fabliau about a merchant, his wife and a monk called Daun John, involving a loan of a hundred francs.

IMPORTANT QUOTATIONS FROM *THE CANTERBURY TALES*

"He was a verray, parfit gentil knyght."
He was a true, perfect, noble knight.
— the Knight, *General Prologue*

"He was as fressh as is the month of May."
— the Squire, *General Prologue*

"And Frenssh she spak ful faire and fetisly, / After the scole of Stratford atte Bowe, / For Frenssh of Parys was to hire unknowe."
She spoke French beautifully and elegantly — in the style of the school at Stratford-at-Bow, for the French of Paris was unknown to her.
— the Prioress (a gentle joke about her provincial French)

"Amor vincit omnia."
Love conquers all.
— the motto on the Prioress's brooch

"And gladly wolde he lerne and gladly teche."
— the Clerk of Oxford, *General Prologue*

"For hym was levere have at his beddes heed / Twenty bookes, clad in blak or reed, / Of Aristotle and his philosophie / Than robes riche, or fithele, or gay sautrie."
He would rather have twenty books of Aristotle, bound in black or red, at the head of his bed than rich robes, a fiddle or a fine harp.
— the Clerk

"Nowher so bisy a man as he ther nas, / And yet he semed bisier than he was."
There was nowhere so busy a man as he, and yet he seemed busier than he was.
— the Man of Law

"For gold in phisik is a cordial, / Therfore he lovede gold in special."
Since gold is a medicine for the heart, he loved gold especially.
— the Doctor of Physic

"Housbondes at chirche dore she hadde fyve."
She had married five husbands at the church door.
— the Wife of Bath

"But Cristes loore and his apostles twelve / He taughte; but first he folwed it hymselve."
He taught the teaching of Christ and His twelve apostles, but first he followed it himself.
— the Parson

"If gold ruste, what shal iren do?"
If gold rusts, what will iron do? — i.e. if the priest is corrupt, how can ordinary people stay good?
— the Parson

"Tales of best sentence and moost solaas."
Tales with the best moral meaning and the most pleasure.
— the Host's rule for the contest

"To maken vertu of necessitee."
To make a virtue of necessity — the origin of the English proverb.
— *The Knight's Tale*

"What is this world? What asketh men to have? / Now with his love, now in his colde grave / Allone, withouten any compaignye."
What is this world? What do men ask to have? Now with one's love, now alone in one's cold grave, without any company.
— dying Arcite, *The Knight's Tale*

"Experience, though noon auctoritee / Were in this world, is right ynogh for me / To speke of wo that is in mariage."
Even if there were no written authority in the world, my own experience would be quite enough for me to speak of the misery of marriage.
— opening of *The Wife of Bath's Prologue*

"Wommen desiren to have sovereynetee / As wel over hir housbond as hir love."
Women desire to have sovereignty (mastery) over their husbands as well as over their lovers.
— *The Wife of Bath's Tale*

"Radix malorum est Cupiditas."
Greed is the root of all evil.
— the Pardoner's text, *The Pardoner's Prologue*

"Love wol nat been constreyned by maistrye. / Whan maistrie comth, the God of Love anon / Beteth his wynges, and farewel, he is gon!"
Love will not be forced by mastery. When mastery comes, the God of Love at once beats his wings, and farewell — he is gone!
— *The Franklin's Tale*

"Pacience is an heigh vertu, certeyn."
Patience is certainly a high virtue.
— *The Franklin's Tale*

"Trouthe is the hyeste thyng that man may kepe."
Truth (keeping one's word) is the highest thing a man can keep.
— *The Franklin's Tale*

"Mordre wol out, that se we day by day."
Murder will come out; we see that day after day.
— *The Nun's Priest's Tale* (also in *The Prioress's Tale*)

"Taketh the fruyt, and let the chaf be stille."
Take the fruit (the moral) and leave the chaff alone.
— end of *The Nun's Priest's Tale*

> *"For thogh we slepe, or wake, or rome, or ryde, / Ay fleeth the tyme; it nyl no man abyde."*
> Whether we sleep, wake, roam or ride, time always flies; it will wait for no man.
> — *The Clerk's Tale* (compare the proverb "Time and tide wait for no man")
>
> *"Tragedie is to seyn a certeyn storie, / … / Of hym that stood in greet prosperitee, / And is yfallen out of heigh degree / Into myserie, and endeth wrecchedly."*
> A tragedy is a story of one who stood in great prosperity and has fallen from high rank into misery, and ends wretchedly.
> — *The Monk's Prologue*
>
> *"Ful wys is he that kan hymselven knowe!"*
> Very wise is he who can know himself!
> — *The Monk's Tale*

Manuscripts, Printing and Translations

More than eighty manuscripts of *The Canterbury Tales* survive. The most famous are the **Ellesmere Manuscript** (now in the Huntington Library, California), beautifully decorated with pictures of the pilgrims, and the **Hengwrt Manuscript** (National Library of Wales). The tales survive in ten groups called **"fragments"**, and their exact intended order is uncertain. **William Caxton** printed the *Tales* in about **1476–77**, one of the first books printed in England, and again with woodcut pictures in **1483**. Later poets made modern versions of some tales: **Dryden** in *Fables Ancient and Modern* (1700), **Alexander Pope** ("January and May") and **William Wordsworth** ("The Prioress's Tale"). The best-known modern English verse translation is by **Nevill Coghill** (1951).

3.5.7 Short Poems and Prose

- ***A Treatise on the Astrolabe*** (1391) — a **prose** handbook on how to use the astrolabe (an instrument for measuring the positions of the stars), written for his ten-year-old son **"lyte Lowys"** (little Lewis). It is one of the **earliest scientific or technical works in English**.
- **"Truth"** (also called the *Balade de Bon Conseyl*, "Ballad of Good Advice") — advises the reader to flee the crowd and live with truth: *"Flee fro the prees, and dwelle with sothfastnesse."*
- **"The Complaint of Chaucer to His Purse"** — a witty poem, addressed to **King Henry IV**, in which the poet complains to his empty purse as if to a lady he loves: *"To yow, my purse, and to noon other wight / Complayne I, for ye be my lady dere."* The king responded by renewing his pension. It is probably Chaucer's **last poem**.
- **"Lak of Stedfastnesse"**, **"Gentilesse"** and **"Fortune"** — short moral ballades.

3.5.8 Chaucer's Art and Contribution

1. **The father of English realism and characterization.** Chaucer was the first English writer to show real, living men and women, each with a face, voice and personality. His pilgrims represent **every class of 14th-century society** except the very highest (the king and great lords) and the very lowest (serfs).
2. **Humour and irony.** His humour is broad and kindly. He laughs at human weakness but rarely condemns it. His irony is gentle: the "innocent" narrator praises the Monk or the Friar, and leaves us to see their faults for ourselves.
3. **Master storyteller.** He uses every kind of story: romance, fabliau, saint's life, beast fable, sermon, Breton lay, tragedy, allegory and parody — and fits each tale to its teller. In this sense *The Canterbury Tales* has been called a forerunner of the **novel** and of **drama**.
4. **Makes English a literary language.** At a time when the court still read French and the learned wrote Latin, Chaucer proved that English could be as graceful as any language. He wrote in the **London (East Midland) dialect**, which, partly because of his fame, became the basis of **Standard English**.
5. **New metres from France and Italy.** He brought the regular **iambic pentameter** (five-beat, ten-syllable line) into English. He introduced the **heroic couplet** (first in *The Legend of Good Women*), later used by Dryden and Pope, and the **rhyme royal** stanza (first in *The Parliament of Fowls*) — seven lines of iambic pentameter rhyming **ababbcc**. This stanza was later called "rhyme royal" because **King James I of Scotland** used it in *The Kingis Quair*; it is also called the **Chaucerian stanza**. Shakespeare used it in *The Rape of Lucrece*.
6. **Bridge between the Middle Ages and the Renaissance.** His interest in classical stories, his debt to Dante, Petrarch and Boccaccio, and his curiosity about this world rather than only the next, make him a herald of the Renaissance.

3.5.9 What the Critics Said

- **John Dryden** (Preface to *Fables Ancient and Modern*, 1700): *"As he is the father of English poetry, so I hold him in the same degree of veneration as the Grecians held Homer, or the Romans Virgil."* Of the pilgrims he wrote: ***"'Tis sufficient to say, according to the proverb, that here is God's plenty."*** He also called Chaucer *"a perpetual fountain of good sense."*
- **Edmund Spenser** (*The Faerie Queene*, Book IV): *"Dan Chaucer, well of English undefyled, / On Fames eternall beadroll worthie to be fyled."*
- **Lord Tennyson** ("A Dream of Fair Women"): *"Dan Chaucer, the first warbler, whose sweet breath / Preluded those melodious bursts that fill / The spacious times of great Elizabeth / With sounds that echo still."* In the same poem he calls Chaucer *"the morning star of song"*.
- **William Blake** (*Descriptive Catalogue*, 1809): *"As Newton numbered the stars, and as Linnaeus numbered the plants, so Chaucer numbered the classes of men."*
- **Matthew Arnold** (*The Study of Poetry*, 1880) admired Chaucer's *"truth of substance"*, his *"large, free, simple, clear yet kindly view of human life"* and his *"liquid diction"*, but said that his poetry lacks the **"high seriousness"** of the very greatest poets — so, in Arnold's view, Chaucer is not quite one of the supreme classics.
- **William Caxton** praised him as *"the worshipful father and first founder and embellisher of ornate eloquence in our English."*

3.6 William Langland (c. 1332 – c. 1386)

Born: c. 1332, probably in the West Midlands (near the Malvern Hills, Worcestershire; some say Cleobury Mortimer, Shropshire)
Died: c. 1386 (perhaps a little later)
Lived: much of his life in London (Cornhill), with his wife Kitte and daughter Calote
Main title: the poet of the poor; the first great poet of the English common man
Masterpiece: *Piers Plowman* (*The Vision of William concerning Piers the Plowman*)
Verse form: unrhymed alliterative long lines

William Langland is the author of only one work — but that one work, ***Piers Plowman***, is the most important English poem of the 14th century after *The Canterbury Tales*. Where Chaucer looked at society with the amused eye of a courtier, Langland looked at it with the angry and sorrowful eye of a poor, deeply religious man. He is the voice of the **common people**, of the **honest labourer**, and of those who wanted to **reform** a corrupt Church and society.

3.6.1 Life

Very little is known for certain about Langland's life; most of it comes from the poem itself. His name is known from a note in one manuscript, and he hints at it inside the poem: *"I have lyved in londe," quod I, "my name is Longe Wille"* (I have lived in the land, said I; my name is Long Will) — "Long Will" may mean he was tall, and the words *londe* and *Longe Wille* hide the name **Will Langland**. He was probably educated at the priory of **Great Malvern**. He took **minor orders** in the Church but, being married, could not become a priest. In London he earned a poor living by singing psalms and prayers for the souls of the dead. He describes himself as a tall, thin, shabby man who would not bow to the rich.

3.6.2 *Piers Plowman*

Piers Plowman (full title: ***The Vision of William concerning Piers the Plowman***; in Latin, *Visio Willelmi de Petro Ploughman*) is a long **allegorical dream vision** written in **alliterative verse**. Langland spent most of his life writing and rewriting it, and it survives in **three main versions**:

Version	Date (approx.)	Length
A-text	c. 1367 – 1370	about 2,500 lines (unfinished)
B-text	c. 1377 – 1379	about 7,300 lines (the most read)
C-text	c. 1385 – 1388	a revision of B

The poem is divided into sections called **passus** (Latin for "step"). It has two main parts: the ***Visio*** (the Vision of the field of folk, Lady Meed and Piers the Plowman) and the ***Vita*** (the Life of **Do-well, Do-better and Do-best**).

3.6.3 Summary of *Piers Plowman*

The Prologue — the Field Full of Folk. On a warm May morning the dreamer, **Will**, dressed like a wandering hermit, falls asleep beside a stream on the **Malvern Hills**. He dreams of a **"fair feeld ful of folk"** — a field full of people of every kind. On a hill to the east stands a **Tower**, the home of **Truth** (God); in a deep valley below lies a **Dungeon**, the home of **Wrong** (the Devil). Between them the whole of human society is busy: ploughmen working hard, wasters eating up what others grow, merchants, minstrels, jesters, beggars, hermits, **friars** preaching for profit, a **pardoner** selling false pardons, lawyers who will not open their mouths without being paid, and priests who leave their parishes to earn money in London. The Prologue also contains the famous fable of the **rats and mice** who decide to hang a **bell on the cat's neck** but cannot find anyone brave enough to do it.

Passus I — Holy Church. A lovely lady, **Holy Church**, comes down from the Tower and explains the vision. Truth is God, the giver of all good things, and the most precious thing in the world is truth; the man in the Dungeon is the "father of falsehood". Love, she says, is the medicine of heaven and the plant of peace.

Passus II–IV — Lady Meed. The dreamer then sees **Lady Meed** (*meed* means "reward", but also "bribery"), richly dressed, who is about to be married to **False**. The marriage is challenged, and everyone goes to the **King's court at Westminster**. Lady Meed bribes judges, friars and officials, and everyone loves her. The King wants her to marry the knight **Conscience**, but Conscience refuses, saying that Meed corrupts everything. **Reason** supports Conscience. The King finally takes Reason and Conscience as his advisers.

Passus V — The Seven Deadly Sins. Reason preaches to the whole field of folk, and the **Seven Deadly Sins** come forward, one by one, to **confess**: Pride, Lechery, Envy, Wrath, **Avarice** (Covetousness), **Gluttony** and **Sloth**. These are some of the most vivid and comic scenes in medieval literature: Gluttony, on his way to church, is tempted into the tavern and drinks until he collapses; **Sloth**, a lazy priest, admits that he does not know his Lord's Prayer properly but knows the **rhymes of Robin Hood**. This is **one of the earliest references to Robin Hood in English literature**. Then a thousand people set out to seek **Truth**, but nobody knows the way.

End of Passus V and Passus VI — Piers the Plowman. Suddenly a simple farmer, **Piers the Plowman**, puts out his head and says he knows Truth well, for he has served him faithfully for forty years. He offers to show them the way, but first he must plough and sow his **half-acre**. He sets everyone to work. Some work hard; others, the **wasters**, refuse. Piers calls on **Hunger**, and when Hunger attacks them, even the wasters work eagerly — until the harvest comes, and they grow lazy again.

Passus VII — The Pardon. Truth sends Piers a **pardon** for himself and all who help him. When a priest reads it, it contains just two lines: *"Those who have done good shall go into eternal life; those who have done evil, into eternal fire."* The priest says this is no pardon at all. In anger and sorrow Piers **tears the pardon** in two and resolves to give up worldly work for prayer and penance. The quarrel wakes the dreamer.

The *Vita* — Do-well, Do-better and Do-best. In the second part, the dreamer wanders through the world asking what it means to **Do-well, Do-better and Do-best** — that is, how to live a good Christian life. He questions a series of allegorical figures — **Thought, Wit, Study, Clergy, Scripture, Imaginative, Patience** — and meets **Haukyn the Active Man**, whose coat is stained with sins. Gradually **Piers** comes to stand for something greater: the ideal Christian, and finally **Christ** himself in human nature. In one great vision, Christ rides into Jerusalem like a

knight coming to a joust, wearing the "armour" of Piers — human nature. He is crucified and then **harrows Hell** (breaks into Hell and frees the souls of the righteous), while the **Four Daughters of God** — **Mercy, Truth, Righteousness and Peace** — argue and are reconciled. In the last part (*Do-best*), Piers builds the barn of **Unity** (the Church), but **Antichrist** attacks it, and the friars corrupt it from within. At the very end, the knight **Conscience** sets out as a pilgrim to find **Piers the Plowman** again, crying for grace — and the dreamer wakes. The poem ends without a final victory: the search for a truly Christian society goes on.

3.6.4 Themes and Importance

1. **Social satire.** The poem attacks the corruption of every class — especially greedy friars, pardoners, bribe-taking officials, lazy priests and idle beggars.
2. **The dignity of honest labour.** Langland honours the hard-working ploughman, who feeds everyone, as the true model of a good life.
3. **Religious search.** At its heart the poem is a soul's search for **Truth**, **Love** and **salvation**.
4. **Allegory.** Ideas become persons: Lady Meed, Conscience, Reason, Hunger, the Seven Sins. Its method has been compared with John Bunyan's ***The Pilgrim's Progress*** (1678).
5. **The voice of social protest.** During the **Peasants' Revolt of 1381**, the rebel priest **John Ball** used the name of "**Piers Plowman**" in his letters to the rebels, showing how famous the poem had become among ordinary people.
6. **The Alliterative Revival.** It is the greatest poem of the movement that brought back the native English alliterative metre.

3.6.5 Chaucer and Langland Compared

Point	Geoffrey Chaucer	William Langland
Social position	Courtier, official, diplomat	Poor cleric in minor orders
Point of view	Amused, tolerant observer	Earnest moral reformer
Main mood	Humour and irony	Anger, sorrow and religious longing
Method	Realism: living individuals	Allegory and dream vision
Verse	Rhymed, syllabic (heroic couplet, rhyme royal)	Unrhymed alliterative long line
Influences	French and Italian poets	The native English tradition and the Bible
Readers	Court and educated middle class	The common people and clergy
Great work	*The Canterbury Tales*	*Piers Plowman*

IMPORTANT QUOTATIONS FROM *PIERS PLOWMAN*

"In a somer seson, whan softe was the sonne, / I shoop me into shroudes as I a sheep weere, / In habite as an heremite unholy of werkes, / Wente wide in this world wondres to here."

In a summer season, when the sun was soft, I dressed myself in rough clothes like a shepherd, in the habit of a hermit unholy in his deeds, and went wide in this world to hear of wonders.

— B-text, Prologue, lines 1–4

"A fair feeld ful of folk fond I ther bitwene — / Of alle manere of men, the meene and the riche, / Werchynge and wandrynge as the world asketh."

Between them I found a fair field full of folk — all kinds of men, the poor and the rich, working and wandering as the world requires.

— B-text, Prologue

"Whan alle tresors arn tried, Treuthe is the beste."

When all treasures are tested, Truth is the best.

— Holy Church, Passus I

"Love is the plante of pees, and moost precious of vertues."

Love is the plant of peace and the most precious of virtues.

— Holy Church, Passus I

"Chastite withouten charite worth cheyned in helle."

Chastity without charity (love) will be chained in hell.

— Passus I

"I kan noght parfitly my Paternoster as the preest it syngeth, / But I kan rymes of Robyn Hood and Randolf Erl of Chestre."

I don't know my Lord's Prayer perfectly as the priest sings it, but I know the rhymes of Robin Hood and Randolph, Earl of Chester.

— Sloth, Passus V

"I have lyved in londe," quod I, "my name is Longe Wille."

I have lived in the land, said I; my name is Long Will.

— Passus XV (a hidden signature)

3.7 John Wycliffe (c. 1330 – 1384)

Name also spelt: Wyclif, Wycliff, Wickliffe
Born: c. 1330, Hipswell, Yorkshire
Died: 31 December 1384, Lutterworth, Leicestershire
Profession: Oxford theologian and philosopher; Master of Balliol College; Rector of Lutterworth
Main titles: The Morning Star of the Reformation; the Father of English Prose (in some books)
Great achievement: the first complete translation of the Bible into English
Followers: the Lollards

John Wycliffe was a brilliant **Oxford scholar**, a fearless **religious reformer** and a pioneer of **English prose**. About 150 years before **Martin Luther** began the Protestant Reformation in Germany (1517), Wycliffe attacked the wealth and corruption of the Church and declared that the **Bible**, not the Pope, is the highest authority for Christians. For this reason he is called **"the Morning Star of the Reformation"**.

3.7.1 Life

Wycliffe was born in **Yorkshire** and studied and taught at **Oxford**, where he became **Master of Balliol College** (c. 1360) and a Doctor of Theology (1372). He was regarded as the leading philosopher at Oxford. In **1374** he was sent by the king to **Bruges** to negotiate with the Pope's representatives, and in the same year he became **Rector of Lutterworth**. The powerful **John of Gaunt** (Chaucer's patron) protected him for many years, because Wycliffe's argument that the Church should not hold

great wealth and political power suited the nobles, who resented paying money to the Pope.

In **1377 Pope Gregory XI** condemned eighteen of his teachings. The **Great Schism** of **1378**, when two rival Popes cursed each other, made Wycliffe attack the papacy even more boldly; he called the Pope **Antichrist**. In **1379–80** he denied the doctrine of **transubstantiation** (the belief that the bread and wine of the Mass become the actual body and blood of Christ), and this cost him the support of John of Gaunt and of the University. After the **Peasants' Revolt of 1381**, many blamed his ideas for the unrest, although he did not support the rebels. In **1382** the **Blackfriars Council** in London — called the **"Earthquake Synod"** because an earthquake shook London during its meeting — condemned his teachings, and his followers were driven out of Oxford. Wycliffe retired to **Lutterworth**, where he continued writing. He suffered a stroke while hearing Mass and died on **31 December 1384**.

Long after his death, the **Council of Constance** (**1415**) declared him a **heretic**. In **1428**, on the Pope's order, his bones were **dug up and burned**, and the ashes thrown into the **River Swift** near Lutterworth. The 17th-century historian **Thomas Fuller** wrote a famous comment on this: *"Thus the brook hath conveyed his ashes into Avon, Avon into Severn, Severn into the narrow seas, they into the main ocean. And thus the ashes of Wickliffe are the emblem of his doctrine, which now is dispersed the world over."*

3.7.2 His Teachings

1. **The Bible is the highest authority** — above the Pope and the Church — and every Christian should be able to read it in his or her own language.
2. **Dominion by grace:** in his Latin works *De Dominio Divino* (On Divine Lordship) and *De Civili Dominio* (On Civil Lordship), he argued that all lordship and property come from God, and that a priest who lives in sin loses the right to his property. So the state could take away the wealth of a corrupt Church.
3. He attacked the **Pope's power**, the wealth of monks and bishops, **indulgences** (the sale of pardons), **pilgrimages**, the worship of images and relics, and compulsory confession to priests.
4. He denied **transubstantiation**.
5. He sent out **"Poor Priests"** — simple preachers in plain russet robes who travelled through the country preaching in English.

3.7.3 The Wycliffite Bible

Wycliffe's most important achievement was the **first complete translation of the whole Bible into English** (c. **1382–1395**). He inspired and led the work, though much of it was done by his followers. It was translated from the **Latin Vulgate** (the official Latin Bible of St Jerome), **not** from the original Hebrew and Greek. It exists in two versions:

- **The Early Version** (c. 1382) — very literal, following the Latin word order closely; much of the Old Testament was translated by **Nicholas of Hereford**.
- **The Later Version** (c. 1388–1395) — smoother and more natural English, revised mainly by Wycliffe's secretary **John Purvey**.

Since printing had not yet come to England, the Bible was **copied by hand**; about 250 manuscripts survive, which shows how widely it was read. In **1409** the **Constitutions of Oxford**, issued by **Archbishop Thomas Arundel**, forbade anyone to translate the Bible into English or to read such a translation without the approval of a bishop.

FROM THE WYCLIFFITE BIBLE (LATER VERSION)

"In the bigynnyng God made of nouyt hevene and erthe."
In the beginning God made heaven and earth out of nothing.
— Genesis 1:1

"In the bigynnyng was the word, and the word was at God, and God was the word."
In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God.
— John 1:1

"Oure fadir that art in hevenes, halewid be thi name; thi kyngdoom come to; be thi wille don in erthe as in hevene."
Our Father who art in heaven, hallowed be Thy name; Thy kingdom come; Thy will be done on earth as in heaven.
— Matthew 6:9–10, the Lord's Prayer

The English Bible — a chain of "firsts":

- **John Wycliffe** (c. 1382–95): the **first complete English Bible** — handwritten, translated from Latin.
- **William Tyndale** (1526): the **first printed English New Testament**, translated from the Greek.
- **Miles Coverdale** (1535): the **first complete printed English Bible**.
- **The King James Version** or **Authorized Version** (1611): the most famous and influential English Bible.

3.7.4 Other Works

Wycliffe wrote most of his scholarly works in **Latin**: *De Dominio Divino* (1375), *De Civili Dominio* (1376), *De Veritate Sacrae Scripturae* (On the Truth of Holy Scripture, 1378), *De Ecclesia* (On the Church, 1378), *De Officio Regis* (On the Office of the King, 1379), *De Potestate Papae* (On the Power of the Pope, 1379), *De Eucharistia* (1379–80) and *Trialogus* (1382). He and his followers also wrote many **English sermons** and short **tracts** (pamphlets) for ordinary people. It is not always certain which of these Wycliffe wrote himself.

3.7.5 Wycliffe and English Prose

Wycliffe chose to write for ordinary people in **plain, direct and forceful English**. By putting the Bible and serious religious argument into English, he showed that English prose could carry the most important ideas of the age. His Bible spread a common English to readers all over the country and introduced many Latin-derived words into the language. For these reasons some books call him **"the Father of English Prose"**.

"Father of English Prose" — three answers you may meet: King Alfred the Great is the Father of English Prose for the **Old English** period. In the **Middle English** period the title is usually given to **John Wycliffe**. Older books sometimes gave it to **Sir John Mandeville**, the supposed author of *The Travels* (see 3.10.3). For exams, the most common answer is **King Alfred**; for the Middle English period, **Wycliffe**.

3.7.6 The Lollards and Wycliffe's Influence

Wycliffe's followers were called **Lollards** — probably from a Middle Dutch word *lollaert*, meaning a "mumbler" (of prayers). After his death they were persecuted; under the law ***De heretico comburendo*** (**1401**, "On the burning of heretics") many were burned. The Lollard leader **Sir John Oldcastle** (Lord Cobham) was executed in **1417**. Oldcastle is remembered in literature because Shakespeare's comic knight **Sir John Falstaff** (in *Henry IV*) was originally named **Oldcastle**; the name was changed after protests from Oldcastle's descendants.

Wycliffe's ideas spread to **Bohemia** (in today's Czech Republic) through students who had studied at Oxford. There they inspired the reformer **Jan Hus** (John Huss), who was burned at the Council of Constance in **1415**. Hus, in turn, influenced **Martin Luther**. In this way Wycliffe's "morning star" led to the full daylight of the Reformation.

POPULAR ATTRIBUTION

"This Bible is for the government of the people, by the people, and for the people."

This sentence is very often said to come from the prologue of Wycliffe's Bible and to have inspired Abraham Lincoln's phrase in the Gettysburg Address (1863). However, scholars have not found it in any of Wycliffe's writings, so it should be treated as a popular attribution rather than a proven quotation.

3.8 Sir Thomas Malory (c. 1415 – 1471)

Born: c. 1415–1418, probably at Newbold Revel, Warwickshire
Died: 14 March 1471, in or near Newgate Prison, London; buried at Greyfriars Church nearby
Description: a "knight-prisoner" who wrote his great book in prison
Masterpiece: *Le Morte d'Arthur* (*The Death of Arthur*), finished 1469–70
Printed by: William Caxton, at Westminster, in 1485
Importance: the greatest English prose work of the 15th century; the standard English version of the legend of King Arthur

Sir Thomas Malory gathered the many French and English stories of **King Arthur and the Knights of the Round Table** into one great book in **English prose**. *Le Morte d'Arthur* is the most famous and influential telling of the Arthurian legend in English, and it marks the high point of English prose before the Renaissance.

3.8.1 Life

The author names himself at the end of his book as **"Sir Thomas Maleoré, knight"**, and asks his readers to pray that God will send him **"good deliverance"** — that is, release from prison. Most scholars identify him with **Sir Thomas Malory of Newbold Revel** in Warwickshire. This Malory was a soldier, was knighted in about 1441, and became a **Member of Parliament** for Warwickshire in 1445. But during the disorder of the **Wars of the Roses** he was accused of many crimes — robbery, cattle-stealing, extortion, violent attacks, raiding an abbey and an attempt to ambush the **Duke of Buckingham**. He was never brought to a full trial, but he spent most of his last twenty years in various **prisons**, including Newgate in London, escaping more than once. It was probably in prison, where he may have had access to a good library, that he wrote his book. He died in **March 1471**.

3.8.2 *Le Morte d'Arthur*

Although its title is French (Malory called it "the hoole book of kyng Arthur and of his noble knyghtes of the Rounde Table"; Caxton gave it the title *Le Morte Darthur*), the book is written in **English prose**. Malory finished it in the **ninth year of the reign of King Edward IV**, that is, between March **1469** and March **1470**.

Sources: Malory used the great French prose romances of the 13th century (the **Vulgate Cycle** and the **Prose Tristan**) and the English poems the alliterative ***Morte Arthure*** and the stanzaic ***Le Morte Arthur***. He shortened, rearranged and simplified them, cutting much of the religious explanation and keeping the action.

Caxton's edition (1485): William Caxton printed the book at Westminster on **31 July 1485** — only weeks before the Battle of Bosworth. He divided it into **21 books** and **507 chapters**, and wrote a famous **preface** recommending it to readers.

The Winchester Manuscript (1934): For more than 400 years Caxton's printed edition was the only known text. Then in **1934 Walter Oakeshott** discovered a handwritten copy of Malory's work in the library of **Winchester College**. It showed that Malory had written the work as **eight separate tales** and that Caxton had edited it. The scholar **Eugène Vinaver** published this text in **1947** as ***The Works of Sir Thomas Malory***.

The eight tales of the Winchester Manuscript are:

1. The Tale of King Arthur
2. The Tale of King Arthur and the Emperor Lucius
3. The Tale of Sir Lancelot du Lake
4. The Tale of Sir Gareth of Orkney
5. The Book of Sir Tristram de Lyones
6. The Tale of the Sankgreal (the Holy Grail)
7. The Book of Sir Lancelot and Queen Guinevere
8. The Most Piteous Tale of the Morte Arthur (the Death of Arthur)

3.8.3 Summary of *Le Morte d'Arthur*

The birth and rise of Arthur. King **Uther Pendragon** loves **Igraine**, the wife of the Duke of Cornwall. With the help of the magician **Merlin**, who changes his appearance, Uther comes to her at **Tintagel** castle, and **Arthur** is born. Merlin takes the baby

away and has him brought up secretly by Sir Ector. After Uther's death, England has no king. A **sword** appears in a **stone** in a London churchyard, with a golden inscription: whoever can pull it out is the true king. All the great lords fail; the boy Arthur pulls it out easily and is crowned. Later he receives the magic sword **Excalibur** from the **Lady of the Lake**. He marries **Guinevere**, daughter of King Leodegrance, who brings as her dowry the **Round Table**, at which a hundred and fifty knights can sit as equals. Arthur then defeats rebel kings and even the **Roman Emperor Lucius**, and is crowned emperor in Rome.

The adventures of the knights. The middle books tell the adventures of the knights of the Round Table: the greatest of them, **Sir Lancelot du Lake**; **Sir Gareth**, who serves humbly in Arthur's kitchen under the nickname **Beaumains** ("Fair Hands") before proving himself; and **Sir Tristram**, whose tragic love for **Isode** (Isolde), the wife of his uncle King Mark of Cornwall, forms the longest section of the book.

The Quest of the Holy Grail. At the feast of Pentecost the **Holy Grail** (the cup used by Christ at the Last Supper) appears in Arthur's hall, and the knights vow to seek it. Many fail because of their sins. Even Lancelot, the best of earthly knights, is allowed only a partial vision, because of his sinful love for Guinevere. The Grail is finally achieved by **Sir Galahad**, Lancelot's son, the perfect and pure knight who sits in the **Siege Perilous** (the dangerous seat at the Round Table, kept for the knight who would achieve the Grail), together with **Sir Percival** and **Sir Bors**. Galahad dies in a state of holiness, and the quest also costs the lives of many knights.

The fall of the Round Table. Lancelot and **Queen Guinevere** have long loved each other. **Sir Agravain** and **Sir Mordred** — Mordred is Arthur's son by his half-sister **Morgause** — expose the lovers to the King. Lancelot escapes, but Guinevere is sentenced to be burned. Lancelot rescues her and, in the fighting, unknowingly kills **Sir Gareth** and his brother **Gaheris**, the beloved brothers of **Sir Gawain**. Gawain, mad with grief, demands vengeance, and Arthur goes to war against Lancelot in France. While Arthur is away, **Mordred seizes the throne** and tries to marry Guinevere. Arthur returns. Gawain dies of his wounds after writing to Lancelot to forgive him.

The death of Arthur. On the eve of the last battle, a truce is arranged; but an adder bites a knight, he draws his sword to kill it, both armies see the flash of steel, and the terrible **battle near Salisbury** begins. Almost everyone is killed. Arthur kills Mordred with a spear, but Mordred, with his last strength, gives Arthur a mortal wound. The dying king orders **Sir Bedivere** to throw **Excalibur** into the lake. Twice Bedivere hides the sword; the third time he throws it, and a hand rises from the water, catches it, waves it three times and draws it under. A barge carrying three queens, including Arthur's half-sister **Morgan le Fay**, takes Arthur away to the **Isle of Avalon** to be healed. Malory says that some people believe Arthur is not dead but will come again. Guinevere becomes a nun at **Amesbury**; Lancelot becomes a priest and hermit. After Guinevere's death Lancelot wastes away and dies, and his brother **Sir Ector** speaks a famous lament over his body.

3.8.4 Main Characters

Character	Who he or she is
King Arthur	King of Britain, founder of the Round Table
Queen Guinevere	Arthur's wife; Lancelot's lover
Merlin	The great magician and adviser; finally trapped by the enchantress Nimue (Nyneve)
Sir Lancelot du Lake	The greatest knight of the world; Guinevere's lover
Sir Galahad	Lancelot's son; the perfect, pure knight who achieves the Grail
Sir Gawain	Arthur's nephew; brave but vengeful
Sir Gareth (Beaumains)	Gawain's brother; the humble kitchen-knight
Sir Tristram and **Isode**	Tragic lovers; Isode is the wife of King Mark of Cornwall
Sir Percival and **Sir Bors**	Galahad's companions in the Grail quest
Sir Kay	Arthur's foster-brother and steward; boastful and sharp-tongued
Sir Bedivere	The last knight to stay with Arthur; returns Excalibur to the lake
Sir Mordred	Arthur's son and destroyer; the traitor
Morgan le Fay	Arthur's half-sister; an enchantress hostile to him
The Lady of the Lake	Gives Arthur the sword Excalibur
Elaine of Astolat	The "Fair Maid of Astolat", who dies of love for Lancelot

3.8.5 Malory's Style and Importance

1. **Simple, noble prose.** Malory writes in a plain, flowing, rhythmic prose, with short sentences joined by "and", and with lively dialogue. His style is direct but dignified, and its sadness in the final books is deeply moving.
2. **The last great work of medieval chivalry.** Written during the brutal Wars of the Roses, the book looks back with longing to an ideal age of knighthood, loyalty and courtesy — and shows how that ideal is destroyed by divided loyalties, jealousy and revenge.
3. **The first great prose romance in English** — some critics call it an epic in prose.
4. **A source for later writers.** It inspired **Edmund Spenser** (*The Faerie Queene*), **Lord Tennyson** ("Morte d'Arthur", 1842, and the ***Idylls of the King***, 1859–1885), **William Morris** (*The Defence of Guenevere*), **Algernon Swinburne** (*Tristram of Lyonesse*), **Mark Twain** (*A Connecticut Yankee in King Arthur's Court*, 1889), **T. H. White** (*The Once and Future King*, 1958) and **John Steinbeck**.
5. **Criticism.** The Renaissance scholar **Roger Ascham**, in *The Scholemaster* (1570), disapproved of the book, saying that its *"whole pleasure … standeth in two special points, in open manslaughter and bold bawdry."*

3.8.6 The Growth of the Arthurian Legend

Writer / Work	Date	Contribution
Nennius, *Historia Brittonum*	c. 830	Mentions Arthur as a war-leader who won twelve battles against the Saxons

Writer / Work	Date	Contribution
Geoffrey of Monmouth, *Historia Regum Britanniae*	c. 1136	First full "life" of Arthur; Merlin, Guinevere, Mordred
Wace, *Roman de Brut*	1155	First mention of the **Round Table**
Chrétien de Troyes (French)	c. 1170–1190	Introduced **Lancelot** and the **Grail** (*Perceval*)
Layamon, *Brut*	c. 1200	First telling of Arthur in **English**
Sir Gawain and the Green Knight	late 14th century	The finest English Arthurian poem
Malory, *Le Morte d'Arthur*	1469–70 (printed 1485)	The complete story in English prose
Tennyson, *Idylls of the King*	1859–1885	Victorian retelling in blank verse

IMPORTANT QUOTATIONS FROM *LE MORTE D'ARTHUR*

"Whoso pulleth out this sword of this stone and anvil is rightwise king born of all England."
Whoever pulls this sword out of this stone and anvil is the rightful born king of all England.
— the inscription on the sword in the stone, Book I

"And much more I am sorrier for my good knights' loss than for the loss of my fair queen; for queens I might have enow, but such a fellowship of good knights shall never be together in no company."
I am much sorrier for the loss of my good knights than for the loss of my fair queen; for I could have enough queens, but such a fellowship of good knights will never be together again.
— King Arthur, Book XX

"Hic iacet Arthurus, rex quondam rexque futurus."
Here lies Arthur, the once and future king.
— the inscription Malory says some men report on Arthur's tomb, Book XXI

"Thou were the courteoust knight that ever bare shield … and thou were the truest lover of a sinful man that ever loved woman … and thou were the sternest knight to thy mortal foe that ever put spear in the rest."
— Sir Ector's lament over the dead Lancelot, Book XXI

"Do after the good and leave the evil, and it shall bring you to good fame and renown."
— William Caxton, Preface to *Le Morte d'Arthur* (1485)

3.9 Dante Alighieri (1265 – 1321)

Nationality: Italian (from Florence)
Born: c. May–June 1265, Florence
Died: 14 September 1321, Ravenna, where he is buried
Beloved: Beatrice Portinari, his ideal of love and goodness
Main titles: the Supreme Poet (*il Sommo Poeta*); the Father of the Italian Language
Masterpiece: *The Divine Comedy* (*La Divina Commedia*)
Verse form he invented: terza rima

Dante was **not an English writer**. He is included in English literature courses because he was the greatest poet of medieval Europe, because **Chaucer** read and borrowed from him and so brought his influence into English poetry, and because English poets from **Milton** to **Shelley**, **Tennyson** and **T. S. Eliot** have been deeply influenced by him. Together with **Petrarch** and **Boccaccio**, he is one of the **"Three Crowns"** (*Tre Corone*) of Italian literature.

3.9.1 Life

Dante was born in **Florence** into a family of minor nobility. When he was **nine years old** (1274), he saw **Beatrice Portinari**, a girl of about the same age, and fell in love with her for life. He met her again nine years later, when she greeted him in the street. Beatrice married another man and **died in 1290** at the age of about 24. Dante's love for her, which was pure and spiritual, became the inspiration of his poetry. He himself married **Gemma Donati**.

Dante was active in the politics of Florence and in **1300** became one of its six **priors** (chief magistrates). Florence was divided between two parties, the **White Guelphs** and the **Black Guelphs**. Dante belonged to the Whites. In **1302**, while he was away on a mission to Rome, the Blacks seized power, and Dante was **exiled** and sentenced to death by burning if he ever returned. He **never saw Florence again**. He spent the rest of his life wandering from city to city in northern Italy, living on the generosity of patrons such as **Can Grande della Scala** of Verona, to whom he dedicated the *Paradiso*. He died in **Ravenna** in **1321**, soon after finishing *The Divine Comedy*.

3.9.2 *The Divine Comedy* (c. 1308 – 1321)

The Divine Comedy is a long narrative poem describing an imaginary **journey through the three realms of the dead** — **Hell, Purgatory and Paradise** — over the Easter of the year **1300**. It is regarded as the **greatest work of Italian literature** and one of the greatest poems in the world.

About the title. Dante called it simply ***Commedia*** (Comedy). It is a "comedy" in the **medieval sense**: a story that begins in sorrow (Hell) and ends in happiness (Paradise), written in a simple everyday language rather than in a lofty style. The word **"Divine"** was added in praise by **Boccaccio**, and the title ***La Divina Commedia*** first appeared on an edition printed in Venice in **1555**.

Language. Instead of Latin, the language of learned books, Dante wrote in the **Tuscan Italian** spoken by ordinary people of Florence. This made Tuscan the basis of **standard Italian**, and so Dante is called **"the Father of the Italian Language"**.

Structure. The poem is built on the numbers **three** (for the Holy Trinity) and **ten** (for perfection):

- It has **three parts** (*cantiche*): ***Inferno*** (Hell), ***Purgatorio*** (Purgatory) and ***Paradiso*** (Paradise).
- It has **100 cantos** (sections): one introductory canto plus **33** for each part (**34 + 33 + 33**).
- It is written in **terza rima**, a verse form Dante invented: three-line stanzas rhyming **aba bcb cdc ded** and so on, in which the middle line of each stanza gives the rhyme for the next.
- Each of the three parts ends with the word ***stelle*** ("stars").

The guides. Dante is the traveller. His guide through Hell and Purgatory is the Roman poet **Virgil** (author of the *Aeneid*), who stands for **human reason** and wisdom. Virgil, as a pagan, cannot enter Paradise, so there Dante is guided by **Beatrice**, who stands for **divine love, grace and faith**. At the very end, **St Bernard of Clairvaux** leads him to the vision of God.

3.9.3 Summary of *The Divine Comedy*

Inferno (Hell). The poem opens on the night before Good Friday in 1300, when Dante is **thirty-five** — "midway upon the journey of our life". He finds himself lost in a **dark wood** (a life of sin and error). Three beasts — a **leopard**, a **lion** and a **she-wolf** (often explained as lust, pride and greed) — block his way up a sunlit hill. **Virgil** appears and tells him that he has been sent by Beatrice to guide him by another road: through Hell itself.

Over the **gate of Hell** is written: *"Abandon all hope, ye who enter here."* Just inside, in a kind of vestibule, are the **neutrals** or opportunists, who never took sides between good and evil; they chase a banner for ever and are stung by wasps and hornets. Across the river **Acheron**, Hell is a huge **funnel** sinking to the centre of the earth, with **nine circles**, each lower one holding worse sinners. In each circle the punishment fits the sin (this principle is called ***contrapasso***):

Circle	Sinners	Punishment / famous figures
1. **Limbo**	Virtuous pagans and unbaptized babies	No torment, only longing; the great poets Homer, Horace, Ovid and Lucan
2.	The **lustful**	Blown about for ever by a whirlwind; **Paolo and Francesca**, Cleopatra, Dido, Helen
3.	The **gluttonous**	Lying in filthy, icy rain, guarded by the three-headed dog **Cerberus**
4.	The **greedy** and the **wasteful**	Pushing heavy weights against each other
5.	The **wrathful** and the sullen	Fighting in, or sunk beneath, the muddy river **Styx**
6.	**Heretics**	Lying in burning tombs inside the City of Dis
7.	The **violent**	Against others: in a river of boiling blood; against themselves (suicides): turned into trees; against God and nature: on burning sand under a rain of fire
8. **Malebolge**	The **fraudulent** (in ten ditches)	Flatterers, sellers of Church offices, false prophets, corrupt officials, hypocrites (in heavy gilded lead cloaks), thieves (tormented by serpents), evil counsellors (wrapped in flames — **Ulysses**), sowers of discord, forgers
9. **Cocytus**	**Traitors**	Frozen in a lake of ice; at the centre, **Satan** (Lucifer), with three faces, chews the three greatest traitors: **Judas Iscariot** (who betrayed Christ), and **Brutus** and **Cassius** (who betrayed Julius Caesar)

Two stories from the *Inferno* are especially famous. In **Canto V**, **Francesca da Rimini** tells how she and her husband's brother **Paolo** fell in love while reading the story of Lancelot and Guinevere together, and were killed by her husband; Dante faints with pity. In **Canto XXVI**, **Ulysses** tells how, in old age, he urged his companions to sail beyond the known world in search of knowledge, and was drowned. In **Canto XXXIII**, **Count Ugolino** tells how he and his sons were starved to death in a tower — a story Chaucer retold in *The Monk's Tale*. Climbing down Satan's body, Dante and Virgil pass through the centre of the earth and come out on the other side to see **the stars** again.

Purgatorio (Purgatory). Purgatory is a great **mountain** rising from the sea on the other side of the earth. Here souls who repented before death are cleansed of sin before entering heaven, and they suffer **gladly and with hope**. At the gate an angel marks seven **P**'s (for *peccatum*, "sin") on Dante's forehead. The mountain has **seven terraces**, one for each of the **Seven Deadly Sins** — **Pride, Envy, Wrath, Sloth, Avarice, Gluttony and Lust** — and as Dante climbs each terrace, one P is wiped away. At the top lies the **Earthly Paradise** (the Garden of Eden). There Virgil silently disappears, and **Beatrice** appears in a glorious procession. Dante drinks from the rivers **Lethe** (which washes away the memory of sin) and **Eunoe** (which restores the memory of good deeds), and is made ready to rise to the stars.

Paradiso (Paradise). With Beatrice, Dante rises through the **nine heavenly spheres** — the Moon, Mercury, Venus, the Sun, Mars, Jupiter, Saturn, the Fixed Stars and the **Primum Mobile** (the outermost moving sphere). In each he meets blessed souls: the wise (such as **St Thomas Aquinas**) in the Sun, warriors for the faith in Mars, just rulers in Jupiter, and contemplatives in Saturn. In the sphere of Mars his ancestor **Cacciaguida** foretells Dante's exile. In the sphere of the Fixed Stars, **St Peter, St James and St John** examine him on **faith, hope and love**. Finally he enters the **Empyrean**, the heaven beyond time and space, where the saints are seated in the form of a vast white **Rose**. Beatrice returns to her place among them, and **St Bernard** prays to the Virgin Mary to grant Dante a vision of God. In a flash of light, Dante sees the mystery of the **Holy Trinity** and the union of God and man in Christ. His will and desire are now moved, like a wheel, by **"the love that moves the sun and the other stars"** — the last line of the poem.

3.9.4 Other Works of Dante

- ***La Vita Nuova*** (*The New Life*, c. 1293–1295) — a book of **31 poems** (mostly sonnets and *canzoni*) linked by **prose** commentary, telling the story of his love for **Beatrice** from their first meeting to her death. It ends with Dante's promise to write of her *"what has never been written of any woman"* — a promise fulfilled in *The Divine Comedy*. It was translated into English by the Victorian poet-painter **Dante Gabriel Rossetti**.
- ***Il Convivio*** (*The Banquet*, c. 1304–1307) — an unfinished work in Italian prose explaining philosophy to readers who did not know Latin.
- ***De Vulgari Eloquentia*** (*On Eloquence in the Vernacular*, c. 1303–1305) — written in **Latin**, it defends the use of the common spoken language (the **vernacular**) for serious poetry.
- ***De Monarchia*** (*On Monarchy*, c. 1312–1313) — a political treatise in **Latin** arguing that the **Emperor** and the **Pope** both receive their authority directly from God, so the Pope should not control the state. It was publicly burned in 1329 and later placed on the Church's list of forbidden books.
- ***Rime*** (lyric poems) and ***Eclogues*** (Latin pastoral poems).

3.9.5 Dante's Influence on English Literature

- **Geoffrey Chaucer** was the first English poet to know Dante's work. *The House of Fame* is partly modelled on the *Divine Comedy*; the story of **Ugolino** in *The Monk's Tale* comes from the *Inferno*; and in *The Wife of Bath's Tale* and *The Monk's Tale* Chaucer names him as *"the wise poete of Florence, / That highte Dant"* and *"the grete poete of Ytaille / That highte Dant"*.
- **John Milton's** *Paradise Lost* shares Dante's grand picture of Heaven, Hell and the fallen angels.
- **P. B. Shelley** wrote "Ode to the West Wind" in stanzas built on **terza rima**, and his last poem, *The Triumph of Life*, in terza rima. **Byron** wrote *The Prophecy of Dante*.
- **Lord Tennyson's** poem **"Ulysses"** (*"To strive, to seek, to find, and not to yield"*) develops the voyage of Ulysses in *Inferno* XXVI.
- The story of **Paolo and Francesca** inspired **Leigh Hunt** (*The Story of Rimini*), **Keats** (sonnet "On a Dream") and the sculptor **Rodin** ("The Kiss").
- **T. S. Eliot** used an epigraph from *Inferno* XXVII for "The Love Song of J. Alfred Prufrock", echoed Dante in *The Waste Land* and *Four Quartets*, and wrote: ***"Dante and Shakespeare divide the modern world between them; there is no third."***
- **Thomas Carlyle**, in *On Heroes and Hero-Worship* (1841), described Dante as **the voice of "ten silent centuries"**.
- Famous English translations include those of **Henry Francis Cary** (1814), the American poet **H. W. Longfellow** (1867) and **Dorothy L. Sayers** (1949–1962, in terza rima).

3.9.6 The Italian Background: Petrarch and Boccaccio

Since Chaucer drew so much from the other two "Crowns" of Italian literature, they must be known along with Dante.

Francesco Petrarca (Petrarch, 1304–1374) is called **"the Father of Humanism"**. His ***Canzoniere*** (*Song Book*, also called *Rime Sparse*), a collection of **366 poems**, mostly sonnets, expresses his love for **Laura**, whom he first saw in a church at **Avignon** on 6 April 1327. He perfected the **Petrarchan (Italian) sonnet**: fourteen lines divided into an **octave** (eight lines, rhyming *abbaabba*) and a **sestet** (six lines, *cdecde* or *cdcdcd*). **Sir Thomas Wyatt** and the **Earl of Surrey** introduced this sonnet into English in the 16th century. Petrarch was crowned **poet laureate** in Rome in 1341 — Chaucer's Clerk calls him *"the lauriat poete"*. Chaucer translated one of his sonnets in *Troilus* and took the story of the Clerk's Tale from his Latin version.

Giovanni Boccaccio (1313–1375) wrote ***The Decameron*** (c. 1348–1353), a collection of **100 tales** told by **ten young people** (seven women and three men) who escape the **Black Death** in Florence to a country villa and tell one story each for ten days. Its frame story is often compared with *The Canterbury Tales*. Chaucer used Boccaccio's ***Il Filostrato*** for *Troilus and Criseyde*, his ***Teseida*** for *The Knight's Tale*, and his ***De Casibus Virorum Illustrium*** (On the Falls of Famous Men) for the idea of *The Monk's Tale*. Boccaccio also wrote a *Life of Dante*, gave public lectures on the *Commedia*, and first called it **"divine"**.

The Three Crowns	Beloved lady	Masterpiece
Dante (1265–1321)	Beatrice	*The Divine Comedy*
Petrarch (1304–1374)	Laura	*Canzoniere* (sonnets)
Boccaccio (1313–1375)	Fiammetta	*The Decameron*

IMPORTANT QUOTATIONS FROM DANTE

"Nel mezzo del cammin di nostra vita / mi ritrovai per una selva oscura, / ché la diritta via era smarrita."
Midway upon the journey of our life I found myself within a forest dark, for the straightforward pathway had been lost.
— *Inferno*, Canto I, lines 1–3 (tr. Longfellow)

"Lasciate ogne speranza, voi ch'intrate."
Abandon all hope, ye who enter here.
— inscription over the gate of Hell, *Inferno*, Canto III

"Amor, ch'a nullo amato amar perdona."
Love, which excuses no one who is loved from loving in return.
— Francesca, *Inferno*, Canto V

"Nessun maggior dolore / che ricordarsi del tempo felice / ne la miseria."
There is no greater sorrow than to remember a happy time in the midst of misery.
— Francesca, *Inferno*, Canto V (compare Chaucer's *Troilus*, Book III)

"Fatti non foste a viver come bruti, / ma per seguir virtute e canoscenza."
You were not made to live like brutes, but to pursue virtue and knowledge.
— Ulysses, *Inferno*, Canto XXVI

"Vien dietro a me, e lascia dir le genti."
Follow me, and let the people talk.
— Virgil, *Purgatorio*, Canto V (Karl Marx quoted it in the altered form "Follow your own course, and let people talk")

"Tu proverai sì come sa di sale / lo pane altrui, e come è duro calle / lo scendere e 'l salir per l'altrui scale."
You shall learn how salt is the taste of another man's bread, and how hard a path it is to go down and up another man's stairs.
— Cacciaguida foretells Dante's exile, *Paradiso*, Canto XVII

"E 'n la sua volontade è nostra pace."
And in His will is our peace.
— Piccarda, *Paradiso*, Canto III

"L'amor che move il sole e l'altre stelle."
The love that moves the sun and the other stars.
— the last line of *Paradiso* (Canto XXXIII)

A famous misquotation: *"The hottest places in hell are reserved for those who, in times of great moral crisis, maintain their neutrality"* is often said to be from Dante, and was made popular by U.S. President John F. Kennedy. These words are **not in Dante**. What Dante actually does (in *Inferno* III) is place the **neutrals** — those who never took a side — just inside the gate of Hell, rejected by both Heaven and Hell.

3.10 Other Writers of the Age of Chaucer

3.10.1 John Gower (c. 1330 – 1408)

John Gower, a wealthy and learned gentleman from Kent, was Chaucer's friend; Chaucer called him **"moral Gower"** when he dedicated *Troilus and Criseyde* to him. Gower is remarkable for writing a major long poem in each of the **three languages** of medieval England:

Work	Language	Content
Mirour de l'Omme (*The Mirror of Man*; Latin title *Speculum Meditantis*), c. 1376–79	**French**	An allegory of the struggle of the Vices and Virtues for the human soul, and a survey of the sins of every class
Vox Clamantis (*The Voice of One Crying*), c. 1377–81	**Latin**	A dream-vision of the **Peasants' Revolt of 1381**, in which the rebels appear as wild beasts, and a criticism of every class of society
Confessio Amantis (*The Lover's Confession*), 1390	**English**	His best work (see below)

Confessio Amantis is a poem of about **33,000 lines** in **octosyllabic couplets**. Gower says that **King Richard II**, meeting him in a boat on the Thames, asked him to write "some new thing"; later Gower rededicated it to **Henry of Lancaster** (the future Henry IV). In the poem a Lover, **Amans**, confesses his sins against love to **Genius**, the priest of Venus. To teach him, Genius tells him **141 stories**, arranged under the **Seven Deadly Sins**, taken from Ovid, the Bible, history and legend. At the end Venus shows Amans that he is now too old for love, and he gives it up. The poem is clear, smooth and gentle, but less lively than Chaucer.

Points to remember: Gower's tale of **Apollonius of Tyre** is the source of Shakespeare's play ***Pericles***, in which **Gower himself appears as the Chorus**. His tale of **Florent** tells the same "loathly lady" story as Chaucer's *Wife of Bath's Tale*. He is buried in **Southwark Cathedral**, where his tomb shows his head resting on his three great books.

3.10.2 The Pearl Poet (or Gawain Poet)

The unknown poet called the **Pearl Poet** or **Gawain Poet** lived in the late 14th century and wrote in the dialect of the **North-West Midlands** (around Cheshire and Staffordshire). Four poems in a single manuscript, known as **Cotton Nero A.x** (now in the British Library), are believed to be his: ***Pearl***, ***Cleanness*** (or *Purity*), ***Patience*** and ***Sir Gawain and the Green Knight***. He is the greatest poet of the **Alliterative Revival**.

Sir Gawain and the Green Knight

This poem of **2,530 lines**, divided into **four parts** (called "fitts"), is the **finest Arthurian romance in English verse**. Its stanzas consist of a group of long **alliterative** lines followed by five short **rhyming** lines called the **"bob and wheel"**.

Summary: At **Camelot**, King Arthur's court is celebrating **New Year**. Suddenly a huge knight rides into the hall — he and his horse are entirely **green**. He carries a holly branch and a great axe, and proposes a **"Christmas game"**: any knight may strike him one blow with the axe, if he agrees to receive a return blow **a year and a day** later. **Sir Gawain**, Arthur's nephew, accepts and **cuts off the Green Knight's head**. But the Green Knight calmly picks up his head, which speaks and reminds Gawain to meet him at the **Green Chapel** next New Year, and rides away.

Next autumn Gawain sets out. On his **shield** is a golden **pentangle** (a five-pointed star), the symbol of his perfect virtue. On Christmas Eve he reaches the castle of a lord, **Sir Bertilak de Hautdesert**, who says the Green Chapel is nearby and invites him to stay. Bertilak proposes another game: for three days he will go **hunting**, and Gawain will rest in the castle; at the end of each day they will **exchange whatever they have won**. Each day Bertilak's beautiful **wife** visits Gawain's bedroom and tries to **tempt** him. Gawain remains courteous but faithful, and accepts only kisses — one, then two, then three — which he honestly gives to Bertilak in exchange for the deer, the boar and the fox. But on the third day the lady also offers him a **green girdle** (sash) which, she says, will protect its wearer from death. Fearing for his life, Gawain accepts it — and **hides it** from Bertilak.

At the Green Chapel, the Green Knight swings his axe twice but stops short; the third time he gives Gawain only a **small nick on the neck**. Then he reveals that he is **Bertilak** himself. The two harmless blows were for the two days on which Gawain was honest; the nick was for the third day, when he kept the girdle. The whole adventure was arranged by the enchantress **Morgan le Fay**, to test the pride of Arthur's court and to frighten Queen Guinevere. Gawain is deeply ashamed of his failure and vows to wear the green girdle always as a sign of his fault. When he returns to Camelot, the knights laugh kindly and decide to wear green sashes too, in his honour.

Themes: the testing of **truth and honour**, the conflict between **courtesy** and **chastity**, the human love of life, and the imperfection of even the best of men. At the end of the manuscript is written ***"Hony soyt qui mal pence"*** (Shame on him who thinks evil of it), the motto of the **Order of the Garter**, founded by Edward III. The poem was edited by **J. R. R. Tolkien** (with E. V. Gordon, 1925) and has been translated by Tolkien and, more recently, by **Simon Armitage** (2007).

Pearl

Pearl is an **elegy** and **dream vision** of 1,212 lines in **101 twelve-line stanzas**, using both rhyme and alliteration. A father mourns the loss of his precious **"pearl"** — his little daughter, who died before she was two years old. Falling asleep on her grave in a garden, he dreams that he sees her, now a radiant young queen in heaven, standing across a stream. She explains to him the mysteries of God's grace and shows him the **Heavenly Jerusalem**. In his eagerness to reach her he tries to cross the stream, and wakes up on her grave, comforted and resigned to God's will. It is one of the most beautiful and complex poems in Middle English.

Patience retells the story of the prophet **Jonah**; *Cleanness* uses Bible stories (the Flood, Sodom, Belshazzar's feast) to teach purity.

3.10.3 Sir John Mandeville — *The Travels*

The Travels of Sir John Mandeville (written c. **1357–1371**) claims to be the account of an English knight of **St Albans** who left England in 1322 and travelled for **34 years** through the Holy Land, Egypt, Ethiopia, India, Cathay (**China**) and the land of the legendary Christian king **Prester John**. It describes real places

side by side with wonders: men with no heads and faces in their chests, one-eyed giants, dog-headed people, a fountain of youth, and trees that grow lambs. It also states that the **earth is round** and could be sailed around.

The book was enormously popular for centuries and was read by explorers such as **Christopher Columbus**. Scholars now believe "Mandeville" never existed: the book was **compiled from other travel books** and encyclopaedias, and was first written in **French**, then translated into English (c. 1400). In older histories of literature Mandeville was called **"the Father of English Prose"**, but that title is now usually given to Wycliffe (for Middle English) or to King Alfred (for Old English).

3.10.4 John Barbour (c. 1320 – 1395)

John Barbour, Archdeacon of Aberdeen, wrote ***The Bruce*** (c. **1375**), a long patriotic poem of about 13,000 lines in **octosyllabic couplets**, in the **Scots** language. It tells the life of **Robert the Bruce**, King of Scotland, and the Scottish War of Independence against England, ending in Bruce's great victory at the **Battle of Bannockburn** (**1314**). Barbour is called **"the Father of Scottish Poetry"**. The most famous lines of the poem are a praise of liberty:

> *"A! fredome is a noble thing! / Fredome mayss man to haiff liking."*
> Ah! Freedom is a noble thing! Freedom makes a man able to live as he pleases (and be content).
>
> — John Barbour, *The Bruce*, Book I

3.10.5 The Mystics

The 14th century produced a group of English religious writers called **mystics**, who described the soul's direct, personal experience of God.

- **Richard Rolle** (c. 1300–1349), the **Hermit of Hampole** in Yorkshire, wrote religious lyrics and prose works such as ***The Form of Living*** and ***Ego Dormio***.
- ***The Cloud of Unknowing*** (late 14th century), by an unknown author, teaches that God cannot be known by thought, but only reached through love, across a "cloud of unknowing".
- **Walter Hilton** (d. 1396) wrote ***The Scale (Ladder) of Perfection***.
- **Julian of Norwich** (1342 – c. 1416), an **anchoress** (a woman living alone, enclosed in a cell attached to a church) at Norwich, wrote ***Revelations of Divine Love*** (also called *Showings*), based on visions she received during a serious illness in **1373**. It is believed to be **the earliest surviving book in English written by a woman**. Her most famous words were later quoted by **T. S. Eliot** in "Little Gidding" (*Four Quartets*):

> *"All shall be well, and all shall be well, and all manner of thing shall be well."*
>
> — Julian of Norwich, *Revelations of Divine Love*

- **Margery Kempe** (c. 1373 – after 1438), a merchant's wife from **King's Lynn**, Norfolk, went on pilgrimages to Jerusalem, Rome and Spain, and **dictated** her life story to scribes in the 1430s. ***The Book of Margery Kempe*** is regarded as **the first autobiography in the English language**. In it she describes visiting Julian of Norwich. Its only manuscript was rediscovered in **1934**.

3.10.6 Other Prose Writers

- **John of Trevisa** (c. 1342–1402) translated **Ranulf Higden's** Latin world history, the ***Polychronicon***, into English (**1387**), adding a famous note that English had replaced French in schools.
- **Thomas Usk** (d. 1388) wrote ***The Testament of Love***, an allegorical prose work in imitation of Boethius, written while he was in prison (he was later executed, in 1388).

3.11 The Fifteenth Century (1400 – 1485/1500)

The fifteenth century is often called **the Barren Age**, **the Dark Age** or **the Age of Transition** of English literature, because after the death of Chaucer (1400) no poet of real greatness appeared in England for nearly two hundred years — until Edmund Spenser. The reasons usually given are:

1. **The Wars of the Roses** (1455–1485), the civil war between the **House of Lancaster** (the red rose) and the **House of York** (the white rose), and the long last stage of the **Hundred Years' War**, filled the country with disorder.
2. **The language was changing.** The final *-e* of many words, which was pronounced in Chaucer's time, stopped being pronounced. Later poets therefore could not hear the music of Chaucer's lines, and their own verse became clumsy.
3. **Imitation instead of originality.** Most poets simply copied Chaucer's forms and allegories.

But the age was not entirely barren. **Prose** grew strong (Malory, Caxton, the Paston Letters), the great **mystery and morality plays** flourished, the **popular ballads** were sung, **printing** arrived, and in **Scotland** a brilliant group of poets appeared.

3.11.1 The English Chaucerians

The English poets who followed and imitated Chaucer are called the **English Chaucerians**.

- **Thomas Hoccleve** (or **Occleve**, c. 1368–1426), a clerk in the government's Privy Seal office, knew Chaucer personally and loved him as a master. His chief work, ***The Regement of Princes*** (1411–12), is a book of advice for **Prince Henry** (the future Henry V). It contains a famous **portrait of Chaucer** painted in the margin of the manuscript, and calls Chaucer *"the firste fyndere of our fair langage"*. His ***La Male Regle*** is an amusing confession of his own wild youth in London.
- **John Lydgate** (c. 1370–1451), a monk of **Bury St Edmunds**, was the most prolific poet of the age, writing about 145,000 lines. His chief works are ***The Troy Book*** (1412–20, written for Prince Henry), ***The Siege of Thebes*** (in which Lydgate imagines himself joining Chaucer's pilgrims and telling a new Canterbury tale), ***The Fall of Princes*** (stories of the falls of great men, based on Boccaccio) and ***The Temple of Glas***.
- **Stephen Hawes** (c. 1474 – c. 1523) wrote ***The Pastime of Pleasure*** (1509), a long allegory of a knight's education.

3.11.2 The Scottish Chaucerians (the Makars)

In Scotland, the 15th and early 16th centuries were a golden age of poetry. The Scottish poets, who called themselves **makars** ("makers", that is, poets), admired Chaucer but wrote with much more freshness and power than the English Chaucerians.

- **King James I of Scotland** (1394–1437) was captured by the English as a boy and held prisoner in England for **eighteen years**. In captivity he saw from his prison window a lovely lady walking in the garden — **Lady Joan Beaufort**, whom he later married. He described this in ***The Kingis Quair*** (*The King's Book*, c. 1424). Because this royal poet used Chaucer's seven-line stanza, it came to be called **"rhyme royal"**.
- **Robert Henryson** (c. 1425 – c. 1500), a schoolmaster at Dunfermline, wrote ***The Testament of Cresseid***, a powerful **sequel to Chaucer's *Troilus and Criseyde***. Deserted by Diomede, Cresseid curses Venus and Cupid, and the gods punish her with **leprosy**. As she begs by the roadside with other lepers, **Troilus** rides by; he does not recognise her, but something in her face reminds him of his lost love, and he throws her a purse of gold. When she learns who he was, she repents, sends him a ring and dies. Henryson also wrote ***The Morall Fabillis of Esope the Phrygian*** (thirteen animal fables), ***Orpheus and Eurydice*** and ***Robene and Makyne***, an early **pastoral** dialogue.
- **William Dunbar** (c. 1460 – c. 1520), court poet of **King James IV**, was the most brilliant of the makars. His ***The Thrissil and the Rois*** (*The Thistle and the Rose*, 1503) celebrates the marriage of James IV of Scotland (the thistle) to **Margaret Tudor**, daughter of Henry VII of England (the rose) — the marriage that a century later united the crowns of Scotland and England under James VI and I (1603). His ***Lament for the Makaris*** mourns the dead poets, including Chaucer, Gower, Lydgate and Henryson, with the Latin refrain ***"Timor mortis conturbat me"*** (The fear of death troubles me). He also wrote ***The Golden Targe***, the comic ***Tretis of the Tua Mariit Wemen and the Wedo***, and ***The Flyting of Dunbar and Kennedie*** (a "flyting" is a contest of poetic insults).
- **Gavin Douglas** (c. 1474–1522), Bishop of Dunkeld, completed his ***Eneados*** in **1513** — a translation of **Virgil's *Aeneid*** into Scots, the **first complete translation of a major classical poem into any form of English**. His original prologues to each book include fine descriptions of the Scottish seasons. He also wrote ***The Palice of Honour***.

(**Sir David Lindsay**, the last of the makars, is described in Chapter 04, under the Preparation for the Renaissance.)

3.11.3 Fifteenth-Century Prose

- **Sir Thomas Malory**, ***Le Morte d'Arthur*** (1469–70) — the greatest prose work of the century (see 3.8).
- **The Paston Letters** (1422–1509) — about a thousand letters written by and to members of the **Paston family**, gentry of **Norfolk**. They give a vivid, real picture of family life, business, marriage, lawsuits and violence during the Wars of the Roses.
- **Sir John Fortescue** (c. 1394 – c. 1479), a judge, wrote ***The Governance of England***, one of the first political treatises in English, comparing the limited monarchy of England with the absolute monarchy of France.
- **Reginald Pecock** (c. 1395 – c. 1461), Bishop of Chichester, wrote ***The Repressor of Over Much Blaming of the Clergy*** (c. 1455) in English against the Lollards. Ironically, he was himself condemned for heresy because he said that reason could judge matters of faith.

3.11.4 William Caxton and the Coming of Printing

William Caxton (c. 1422–1491) was a successful English cloth merchant living in **Bruges** (in Flanders, modern Belgium). He became interested in translating French books, and learned the new art of **printing** — invented in Germany by **Johannes Gutenberg** in about 1440–1450 — at **Cologne**. He then set up a press at Bruges.

- ***The Recuyell of the Historyes of Troye*** (c. **1473–74**, printed at **Bruges**) — Caxton's own translation from the French of Raoul Lefèvre; it is **the first book ever printed in the English language**.
- ***The Game and Playe of the Chesse*** (1474, Bruges) — the second book printed in English.
- In **1476** Caxton returned to England and set up the **first printing press in England** near **Westminster Abbey**, at the sign of the Red Pale.
- ***The Dictes or Sayengis of the Philosophres*** (**1477**) — **the first dated book printed in England**.
- He printed about **100 books**, including Chaucer's ***Canterbury Tales*** (c. 1476–77 and 1483), Gower's ***Confessio Amantis*** (1483), Malory's ***Le Morte d'Arthur*** (1485) and ***Aesop's Fables*** (1484). About twenty of his books were his own translations.

Caxton is called **"the first English printer"** or **"the Father of English Printing"**. Because he printed in the **London English** of the court and government, printing helped to **fix this dialect as Standard English** and to make spelling more uniform. Books became cheaper and more plentiful, which prepared the way for the Renaissance and the Reformation. After his death his assistant **Wynkyn de Worde** carried on the business and moved it to **Fleet Street**, which became the centre of the English printing and newspaper trade.

In the prologue to his ***Eneydos*** (1490), Caxton tells a famous story to show how much English varied from place to place. Some merchants sailing down the Thames landed in Kent and asked a woman for **"egges"**. She replied that she could not speak French. Another of them asked for **"eyren"**, and then she understood — both words meant "eggs". *"Lo,"* says Caxton, *"what should a man in these days now write, egges or eyren?"*

3.12 Medieval Drama

English drama, like the drama of ancient Greece, was born from **religion**. In the Middle Ages it grew out of the services of the Church, moved outside into the streets, and passed through three main stages: the **mystery and miracle plays**, the **morality plays** and the **interludes**.

3.12.1 Origins: Liturgical Drama

In the 10th century, small dramatic scenes in **Latin** were added to the church services at Easter and Christmas. The earliest is the Easter **"Quem quaeritis?"** ("Whom do you seek?") — the question of the angels to the women who came to Christ's empty tomb, sung as a little dialogue by priests. Gradually more scenes were added, the plays grew longer and more popular, and they moved from the altar to the church porch and then into the **market-place**. They began to be performed in **English**, by ordinary townspeople instead of priests.

3.12.2 Mystery and Miracle Plays

- **Mystery plays** dramatized stories from the **Bible**, from the **Creation** and the **Fall of Lucifer** to the **Last Judgement**. The name comes from the Latin *ministerium* ("craft" or "trade"), because each play was produced by a **trade guild**, the "mystery" or craft-association of the town. The guilds often chose suitable stories: in York, the **shipwrights** performed the *Building of the Ark* and the **bakers** the *Last Supper*.
- **Miracle plays** dramatized the lives and miracles of the **saints**, especially the Virgin Mary and St Nicholas. In England the two words are often used for the same kind of play.

The plays were performed in **cycles** (series) on movable stages called **pageant wagons**, which rolled from one street-corner to the next, especially during the festival of **Corpus Christi** in early summer. Four great English cycles survive:

Cycle	Number of plays
York	48
Chester	24
Wakefield (also called **Towneley**)	32
N-Town (once wrongly called the *Ludus Coventriae* or Coventry cycle)	42

The plays mixed holy subjects with **comedy and realism**. **Noah's wife** is a shrewish scold who refuses to enter the Ark until she is dragged in. **King Herod** is a ranting, raging tyrant — from which comes Shakespeare's phrase in *Hamlet*, **"it outherods Herod"**, meaning to overact wildly.

The most famous single play is the ***Second Shepherds' Play*** (*Secunda Pastorum*) of the Wakefield cycle, by an unknown dramatist of genius called the **Wakefield Master**. Three poor shepherds complain about the cold and their masters. A rogue called **Mak** steals one of their sheep and hides it in a **cradle**, pretending with his wife **Gill** that it is their newborn baby. The shepherds discover the trick and toss Mak in a blanket as punishment. Then an angel announces the birth of Christ, and the shepherds go to Bethlehem to worship the real holy baby lying in a manger. The comic stolen "lamb" in the cradle cleverly prepares for the true **Lamb of God**. It is admired as the finest comic play of the medieval English stage.

3.12.3 Morality Plays

In the 15th century a new kind of play appeared: the **morality play**. Its characters are **personified abstractions** — Mankind, Good Deeds, Knowledge, Death, the Seven Deadly Sins, Mercy, Mischief — and its purpose is to teach a **moral lesson** about how to live and how to save one's soul.

- ***The Castle of Perseverance*** (c. 1405–1425) — the **earliest complete morality play** in English. The soul of Mankind is besieged in a castle by the Vices.
- ***Mankind*** (c. 1470) — a lively, comic play in which the farmer Mankind is led astray by the rascals **Mischief**, **New-Guise**, **Nowadays** and **Nought**.
- ***Wisdom*** (c. 1460–70) — also called *Mind, Will and Understanding*.
- ***Everyman*** (c. 1495–1510) — **the most famous morality play**, probably translated from the Dutch play *Elckerlijc*.

*Summary of **Everyman**:* **God** sees that people have forgotten Him and sends **Death** to summon **Everyman** to give an account of his life. Terrified, Everyman asks his friends to go with him on this journey. **Fellowship** (friendship), **Kindred** and **Cousin** (family) all promise help but refuse to go. **Goods** (wealth) also refuses and mocks him: riches cannot go beyond the grave. **Good Deeds** would go, but she is too weak to stand, because Everyman has done so few good deeds. Her sister **Knowledge** leads him to **Confession**, and after his penance Good Deeds becomes strong. **Beauty, Strength, Discretion** and **Five Wits** set out with him, but they too desert him at the edge of the grave. Only **Good Deeds** goes down into the grave with Everyman, and an angel receives his soul. The moral: at death, only our good deeds can go with us.

> *"Everyman, I will go with thee, and be thy guide, / In thy most need to go by thy side."*
>
> — Knowledge, *Everyman* (later the motto of the famous Everyman's Library series of books)

> *"Lo, yonder I see Everyman walking. / Full little he thinketh on my coming."*
>
> — Death, *Everyman*

The comic tempter in the morality plays, called **the Vice**, is the ancestor of the clown and the stage villain of Elizabethan drama. The **Good and Evil Angels** in Marlowe's ***Doctor Faustus*** come directly from the morality tradition.

3.12.4 Interludes

At the end of the 15th and the beginning of the 16th century appeared the **interlude** — a short play, often comic, performed between the courses of a banquet or between other entertainments, in the halls of the rich. Interludes deal with ordinary people more than with allegory, and form a bridge from medieval drama to the regular comedy of the Renaissance. Henry Medwall's ***Fulgens and Lucrece*** (c. 1497) is the **earliest surviving secular (non-religious) play in English**. The most famous writer of interludes, **John Heywood**, is studied in Chapter 04.

3.13 The Popular Ballads

A **ballad** is a short **story in song**, composed by unknown people and passed on by word of mouth. The great age of the English and Scottish popular ballads was the 14th and 15th centuries, though most were written down much later.

Features: a simple, dramatic story, often tragic, told without the author's comments; much **dialogue**; **refrains** and **repetition**; and usually the **ballad stanza** — four lines with four and three stresses in turn, rhyming **abcb**.

Main kinds and examples:

- **The Robin Hood ballads** — about the generous outlaw of Sherwood Forest who robs the rich to help the poor. ***A Gest of Robyn Hode*** (printed c. 1500) is the longest. The first literary mention of Robin Hood is in *Piers Plowman* (see 3.6).
- **The Border ballads** — about fighting on the border between England and Scotland: ***Chevy Chase*** and ***The Battle of Otterburn*** (about the fight of the **Percy** and the **Douglas** in **1388**). Sir Philip Sidney later wrote in *The Defence of Poesy*: *"I never heard the old song of Percy and Douglas that I found not my heart moved more than with a trumpet."*
- **Tragic and supernatural ballads** — ***Sir Patrick Spens*** (a Scottish captain drowned at sea on the king's orders), ***The Twa Corbies*** (two ravens plan to feed on a dead knight), ***Lord Randal*** (a young man poisoned by his sweetheart), ***Barbara Allan*** and ***The Wife of Usher's Well***.

These old ballads were collected and published later by Bishop **Thomas Percy** in ***Reliques of Ancient English Poetry*** (**1765**), by **Sir Walter Scott** in ***Minstrelsy of the Scottish Border*** (1802–03) and by the American scholar **F. J. Child** in ***The English and Scottish Popular Ballads*** (305 ballads, 1882–98). Percy's *Reliques* greatly influenced the **Romantic poets**, and Wordsworth and Coleridge called their famous 1798 collection ***Lyrical Ballads***.